The Inedible Scream

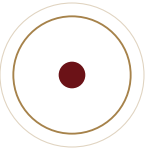




A DISSERTATION

The Inedible Scream

Algophagy, the Sacrificial Broadcast, and the Gnostic Melodrama of Twin Peaks *(1990–2017)*



The Inedible Scream: Algophagy, the Sacrificial Broadcast, and the Gnostic Melodrama of Twin Peaks *(1990–2017)*

Set in EB Garamond, with display capitals in Cinzel. Figures and ornaments drawn for this edition.

Trim 7 × 10 in.

Twin Peaks was created by David Lynch and Mark Frost. This study is an independent work of criticism and is not affiliated with or endorsed by its creators or rights holders.

The way up and the way down are one and the same.

HERACLITUS · FR. B60

Man did eat angels' food.

PSALM 78:25

"If that there King was to wake," added Tweedledum, "you'd go out—bang!—just like a candle!"

LEWIS CARROLL · THROUGH THE LOOKING-GLASS

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that *Twin Peaks*, taken as the totality of its broadcast seasons (ABC, 1990–91), the feature *Fire Walk With Me* (1992), the eighteen-part *The Return* (Showtime, 2017), and the diaries, novels, and dossiers that orbit them, constitutes a single, internally contested mythopoetic system whose organizing substance is *garmonbozia*, the "pain and sorrow" on which the inhabitants of the Black Lodge feed. To name the structure this substance discloses, I coin the term **algophagy** (Gk. *álgos*, pain; *phageîn*, to eat): any order, whether metaphysical, social, familial, epistemic, or technological, in which suffering is extracted from a subject, converted into a transmissible form, and consumed as nourishment, value, or meaning.

Against readings that subordinate the work's metaphysics to postmodern pastiche or to auteurist psychobiography, I demonstrate that *Twin Peaks* distributes a single algophagic structure across five registers that its syncretic sources had held apart: the occult (Theosophical lodges, Gnostic archons, Kabbalistic shells), the social (the Girardian sacrificial community), the familial (the incestuous father and the transgenerational phantom), the epistemic (the detective's melancholic will-to-know), and the technological (electricity, broadcast, and the serial form itself). Genealogically, the study reconstructs the work's inheritance from Böhme, Bulwer-Lytton, Blavatsky, Steiner, Alexandra David-Néel, the Upaniṣadic and Advaitic traditions mediated by Transcendental Meditation, Tibetan funerary literature, Arthurian romance, and the cinema of Preminger, Wilder, and Hitchcock. Comparatively, it situates the work among the *Popol Vuh*, the

Apocryphon of John, the *Hymn of the Pearl*, Dante, Goethe, Carroll, Wilder's *Our Town*, Borges, Lem, Bradbury, Le Guin, King, and Pynchon.

Theoretically, the dissertation fuses Peter Brooks's "moral occult" with Gnostic cosmogony to define a new generic category, the **Gnostic melodrama**, in which melodrama's hidden moral universe is literalized as occult ontology and then turned against its own spectators. Its central claim is that *Twin Peaks* is a self-indicting theory of serial television as a **sacrificial broadcast** that feeds upon the image of a suffering girl, and that Laura Palmer's three terminal gestures, the whisper (1990), the ring (1992), and the scream (2017), compose an escalating poetics of **the inedible**: suffering that refuses conversion into narrative, spectacle, or theodicy. Read through Levinas's "useless suffering," Weil's affliction and attention, and Benjamin's angel of history, the scream that extinguishes the Palmer house emerges as the corpus's final act: a short circuit in which the medium, confronted with a pain it cannot digest, switches itself off. The study concludes by distinguishing the two spectatorships the work dramatizes, the consumptive spectatorship of the Lodge and the attentive spectatorship of the Fireman, and by reading *The Return* as a ritual pedagogy designed to convert the first into the second.

Note on Corpus, Sigla, and Citation

Following Lévi-Strauss's axiom that a myth consists of all its versions, the corpus is treated as one text in several states, its contradictions read as variants rather than errors. **TP** designates *Twin Peaks* (ABC, 1990–91), cited by episode with the pilot numbered 0 and the second-season premiere numbered 8; thus TP 2 contains Cooper's first Red Room dream, TP 14 the revelation of the killer, TP 16 Leland Palmer's death, and TP 29 the series finale. **FWWM** designates *Twin Peaks: Fire Walk With Me* (directed by Lynch; written by Lynch and Robert Engels, 1992); **MP** *The Missing Pieces* (2014); **TR** *Twin Peaks* (*The Return*, 2017), cited by Part; **SDLP** Jennifer Lynch, *The Secret Diary of Laura Palmer* (1990); **SH** Mark Frost, *The Secret History of Twin Peaks* (2016); **FD** Frost, *Twin Peaks: The Final Dossier* (2017); **LL** the Log Lady introductions Lynch wrote for the 1993 Bravo rebroadcast.

Dialogue is paraphrased except where a phrase of a few words is itself the object of analysis. Classical and scriptural texts are cited by conventional divisions (Plato by Stephanus page, Heraclitus by Diels–Kranz number, the *Bhagavad Gītā* by chapter and verse); modern works by author and date of first publication, with full details in the Works Cited. Claims are marked by kind throughout: **genealogical** (documented or acknowledged influence), **homological** (structural correspondence asserted without any claim of intention), and **synthetic** (the dissertation's own construction). Onomastic and paronomastic resonances in particular are advanced as homologies, never as reconstructions of authorial design.

Who Eats Laura Palmer?

The Displaced Question

Twin Peaks was sold to American network television on a single interrogative, "Who killed Laura Palmer?", and the history of its reception is largely the history of that question's misreading. By Lynch's often-repeated account, the mystery was the engine of the series, and its solution, extracted under network pressure in TP 14, killed the goose that laid the golden eggs. The complaint is usually read as an aesthete's preference for open form. This dissertation reads it literally.

The question's productivity lay in its capacity to keep a dead girl in circulation. Each week an audience that at its height numbered in the tens of millions gathered before the image of a seventeen-year-old's corpse and the homecoming portrait that mourned it. The pilot's inaugural image of Laura is a body wrapped in plastic and deposited on a riverbank like freight: packaging precedes personhood. What the series discovered across the twenty-seven years separating its pilot from its final Part is that "Who killed Laura Palmer?" was never its real question. The real question, which the corpus asks with escalating explicitness and finally turns upon its own audience, is *who eats her*.

The answer widens concentrically. In the second season it is BOB, the possessing spirit whose appetite is formalized in FWWM as a debt of garmonbozia owed to his former partner, the Arm. At the familial register it is Leland Palmer, who raped his daugh-

ter from the time she was twelve and finally murdered her; his possession by BOB is at once a supernatural event and the mythic disguise of that abuse. At the social register it is the town. Its leading businessman, Ben Horne, owns One Eyed Jacks, the brothel across the Canadian border where Laura, still a minor, was prostituted, and he had a sexual relationship with her himself; Jacques Renault and Leo Johnson exploited her in a circuit of cocaine and sex; and the town's communal life reorganizes itself around her portrait as around a sacred victim. At the epistemic register it is the detective, Dale Cooper, whose love for the case is from the first a love for a dead girl's image. At the technological register it is the broadcast apparatus, which converts the image of her suffering into ratings. And in the eighth Part of *The Return* it is the cosmos itself, which receives BOB as the by-product of the first atomic detonation and Laura as the White Lodge's reply.

The real question is who eats her.

The Algophagic Hypothesis

I call the structure common to these registers **algophagy**. An order is algophagic when it (i) extracts suffering from a subject, (ii) converts that suffering into a transmissible form, and (iii) consumes the transmitted form as nourishment, value, or meaning. Within the diegesis the substance has a name, garmonbozia; a sacramental appearance, creamed corn; a medium, electricity; and a ritual form, the serial broadcast. The dissertation advances three propositions.

The first is a proposition of **isomorphism**. The occult, social, familial, epistemic, and technological registers of the series are structurally identical, and the corpus's notorious syncretism, its traffic among Theosophy, Vedānta, Tibetan Buddhism, Gnosticism, Arthurian romance, Native American lore, and the iconography of mid-century Hollywood, is best understood not as decorative exotica but as a sequence of attempts to name one structure in mutually incompatible vocabularies.

The second is a proposition of **self-indictment**. The structure includes the work's own medium and audience, so that *Twin Peaks* is a theory of television written on television against television. *Fire Walk With Me* opens with an axe destroying a television set. *The Return* opens with a young man paid to watch an empty glass box, who is slaughtered by what the box summons.

The third is a proposition of **the inedible**. The corpus culminates not in redemption but in the production of three forms of suffering that resist algophagic conversion: the

whisper that cannot be broadcast, the ring that removes a host from circulation, and the scream that shorts the circuit. These three forms constitute the work's ethical content.

A generic claim follows. Peter Brooks (1976) defined melodrama as the mode in which a desacralized modernity expresses its "moral occult," the hidden domain of spiritual forces operative beneath the surface of the real. *Twin Peaks*, which began as at once a parody and an apotheosis of the prime-time soap, literalizes that occult: the hidden moral forces become actual lodges, with furniture. When the literalized occult takes the specific shape of a Gnostic cosmology, with a divine spark sent into a demiurgic world, archons who feed on what they trap, and an apparatus of entrapment that includes the viewing subject, the result is a genre without a name. I call it the **Gnostic melodrama**.

State of the Field

The first wave of scholarship, consolidated in David Lavery's *Full of Secrets* (1995), read the series through the paradigms of its moment: postmodern hybridity, genre parody, the derationalization of detection (the subject of Angela Hague's contribution to that volume), the gendered pleasures of the soap, and, insistently, the problem of Laura's representation as an aestheticized female corpse. Auteurist and psychoanalytic studies followed. Michel Chion (1992; English 1995) supplied the indispensable vocabulary of Lynchian sound; Martha Nochimson (1997; 2013) read Lynch's cinema as an exploration of a subconscious that eludes rationalist control; Slavoj Žižek (2000) named its tonal signature the "ridiculous sublime"; Todd McGowan (2007) offered the most rigorous Lacanian account of its oscillation between desire and fantasy. Greg Olson (2008) produced the standard critical biography, and Allister Mactaggart (2010) located the films in Lynch's painterly practice. David Foster Wallace's 1996 essay remains the canonical attempt to define the adjective "Lynchian" as a particular fusion of the macabre and the mundane.

Television studies, notably Andreas Halskov (2015), has established the series' foundational place in the genealogy of serial "quality" drama. The critical canonization of *The Return*, which *Cahiers du cinéma* ranked first among the films of the 2010s, has relocated the corpus from the history of television to the history of cinema, a relocation Lynch himself encouraged by calling the revival an eighteen-hour film.

Three literatures therefore exist in parallel without integration. The esoteric genealogy of the Lodges is widely noted but rarely theorized. The sacrificial anthropology of the murdered girl is often invoked but seldom extended to the audience. The media theory of electronic presence, above all Jeffrey Sconce's *Haunted Media* (2000), has not been systematically brought to bear on the Lodge cosmology. No study has yet read the ending of 2017 as the theoretical culmination of the premise of 1990. This dissertation undertakes that integration.

Method: Comparative Mythopoetics and Media-Theological Hermeneutics

Two procedures structure the argument. The first, **comparative mythopoetics**, extends Lévi-Strauss's (1955) principle that a myth is the sum of its versions to the treatment of *Twin Peaks* as a myth in that technical sense: series, film, revival, and paratexts are variants, and their contradictions, such as the divergent timelines of TR 17–18 and FD, are data. Comparison seeks homologies rather than sources, that is, structural correspondences between *Twin Peaks* and the mythic and literary traditions it resembles, whether or not its authors knew them.

The second procedure, **media-theological hermeneutics**, reads technical apparatuses as theological symbols and theological symbols as descriptions of apparatuses, following Sconce, Friedrich Kittler (1986), John Durham Peters (1999), and Erik Davis (1998). Its wager is that the Red Room's curtains, chevron floor, strobing light, and reversed speech are not surreal décor but a composite portrait of analog media.

The distinction among genealogical, homological, and synthetic claims matters because *Twin Peaks* trains its interpreters in paranoia, rewarding the forensic decoding of clues. A study of algophagy must remain aware that interpretation is itself a form of consumption, a problem the Conclusion addresses through Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's distinction between paranoid and reparative reading.

Architecture of the Argument

Part One, Genealogies, reconstructs the two metaphysics the work inherits. Chapter 1 traces the Lodges from Jacob Böhme's two fires through Blavatsky's brotherhoods, Bulwer-Lytton's Dweller on the Threshold, and Steiner's Guardian to Hawk's testimony and Frost's occult historiography. Chapter 2 reconstructs Lynch's Vedāntic ontology and argues that the creators' rival metaphysics, Frost's dualism and Lynch's nonduality, are the twin peaks of the title.

Part Two, Structures, analyzes the three structures through which algophagy operates: the double (Chapter 3), the sacrificial community (Chapter 4), and the economy of pain itself (Chapter 5), where the concept receives its full elaboration. **Part Three, Media,** reads the Lodge as an electrical relay and the series as a Gnostic melodrama (Chapter 6), then interprets Part 8 of *The Return* as a Gnostic cosmogony staged in a cinema (Chapter 7). **Part Four, Ends,** follows the corpus to its terminus: the necropoetics of the remade woman and the name of Judy (Chapter 8), the failure of every model of return (Chapter 9), and the poetics of the inedible (Chapter 10). The Conclusion proposes a post-algophagic spectatorship.

PART ONE

Genealogies

I · THE LODGE BEFORE THE LODGES
II · THE SPIDER AND THE DREAMER

CHAPTER ONE

I

The Lodge Before the Lodges

Theosophy, the Threshold, and the American Occult

THE Lodges of *Twin Peaks* are inheritances, not inventions. They condense four centuries of Western esoteric dualism, from Jacob Böhme's two fires through Blavatsky's two brotherhoods to Rudolf Steiner's Guardian of the Threshold, into a single architectural figure, and they relocate that figure onto American ground already claimed by settler fantasies of Indigenous wisdom. This chapter reconstructs that genealogy and identifies the structural asymmetry it bequeaths to the series: in *Twin Peaks*, evil is shown and good is narrated.

From Böhme's Two Fires to Blavatsky's Brotherhoods 1.1

The term *theosophy* belonged to the Görlitz shoemaker Jacob Böhme (1575–1624) long before Helena Petrovna Blavatsky claimed it. In *Aurora* (1612) and *De tribus principiis* (1619), Böhme posits within the divine an *Ungrund*, an abyss without ground, from which God's self-manifestation proceeds through two principles: a dark fire of wrath, contraction, and anguish, and a light fire of love, expansion, and joy. Their tension is the condition of life itself. The dark fire is not evil but becomes evil when it is severed from the light it was meant to kindle.

Schelling's *Freiheitsschrift* (1809) systematized this intuition as the distinction between the ground (*Grund*) of existence and existence proper. God cannot dispense with the dark ground, but it must remain subordinate; evil arises when the creature's self-will

usurps the center it was meant to serve. Schelling's formula is the most precise available description of possession as *Twin Peaks* depicts it. BOB is not a substance but an insurrection of the ground, a self-will that seizes the center of another's life and governs from there.

Blavatsky, who founded the Theosophical Society in New York in 1875 with Henry Steel Olcott, retained Böhme's word and transformed his polarity from ontology into organization. Across *Isis Unveiled* (1877), *The Secret Doctrine* (1888), and *The Theosophical Glossary* (1892), the cosmos is administered by a hierarchy of Masters of Wisdom and resisted by the "Brothers of the Shadow" of the left-hand path. Her successors made the institutional metaphor explicit. C. W. Leadbeater (1925) and Alice Bailey (1922) speak of a Great White Lodge or Brotherhood. Dion Fortune's *Psychic Self-Defence* (1930) describes black lodges whose adepts drain the vitality of their victims, an occult vampirism that is the most direct precursor of garmonbozia in the esoteric literature.

The word *lodge* carries at least four sedimented senses in *Twin Peaks*. It is the Masonic lodge, whose vocabulary of degrees, oaths, and secrecy saturated nineteenth-century American fraternal life and survives in the Bookhouse Boys and, in TR 14, in a roadside bar called Elk's Point #9. It is the Theosophical lodge, both the local branch of the Society and the occult Hierarchy itself. It is the hunting lodge, of which the Great Northern Hotel is the timber baron's rustic palace. And it is the Indigenous ceremonial lodge, the sweat lodge or the medicine lodge of the Anishinaabe Midewiwin. The word thus triple-codes fraternal, esoteric, and Indigenous institutions, and with them the settler appropriation that binds them.

One asymmetry structures the entire inheritance. In the original series the White Lodge is attested only by testimony: Hawk's lore, Major Briggs's vision of a palace of light (TP 8), and Windom Earle's sermon. It is never shown. The Black Lodge alone is visualized, as the Red Room. Evil is shown; good is narrated. Chapter 6 will argue that this asymmetry is a theory of the medium, and Chapter 7 that the White Lodge becomes visible only when the corpus becomes cinema, in TR 8.

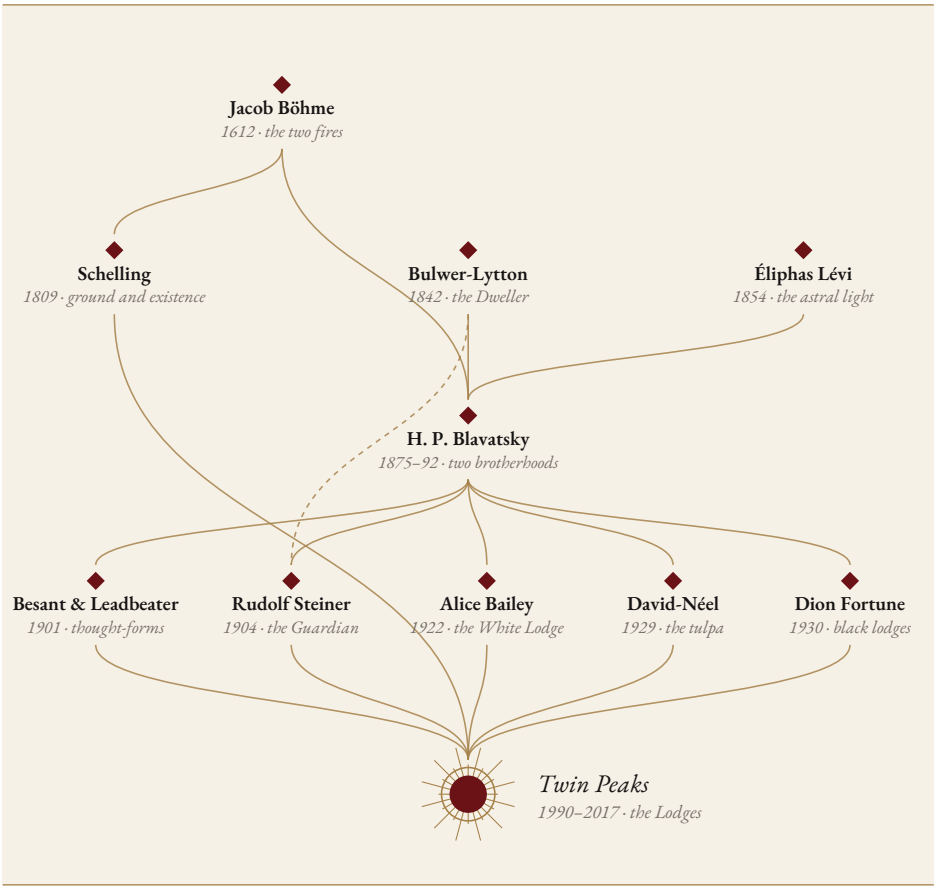


FIG. 1 *The Lodge before the Lodges: a stemma of the esoteric sources, from Böhme's two fires to the Lodges of Twin Peaks. Solid lines mark transmission; the dashed line marks the descent of Bulwer-Lytton's Dweller into Steiner's Guardian.*

The Dweller on the Threshold: Bulwer-Lytton, Steiner, and Hawk's Testimony 1.2

In the second season, Deputy Hawk explains the cosmology to Cooper. The White Lodge is where the spirits that rule man and nature reside; the Black Lodge is its shadow, through which every spirit must pass on its way to perfection; there one meets one's own shadow self, which Hawk's people call the Dweller on the Threshold; and whoever confronts it with imperfect courage will have his soul annihilated.

The phrase is not Indigenous. It was coined by Edward Bulwer-Lytton in *Zanoni* (1842) for the hideous phantom that confronts the neophyte Glyndon when he violates the discipline of initiation by inhaling a forbidden elixir in his master's absence. Blavatsky's *Glossary* absorbed the term with acknowledgment. Rudolf Steiner, General

Secretary of the German Theosophical section from 1902 before founding Anthroposophy, gave it its most rigorous form in *Knowledge of the Higher Worlds* (1904–05). There the lesser Guardian of the Threshold is the aspirant's own double, a spectral composite of his unredeemed deeds that he must recognize as himself before he may pass. A greater Guardian, a luminous being whom Steiner's later lectures associate with Christ, then summons him to defer his own liberation until all humanity is freed.

This is the exact structure of Cooper's ordeal in TP 29. The Lodge presents him with his double, and his flight from it, an act of imperfect courage driven by guilt over Caroline Earle, the witness and lover he failed to protect from her husband Windom Earle, who murdered her, and by terror for Annie Blackburn, whom Earle has abducted, releases the double into the world for twenty-five years. Steiner's double is accumulated karma; Cooper's is the precipitate of his attachments.

The genealogy exposes an act of ventriloquism. A Victorian novelist's coinage, refracted through Theosophy and Anthroposophy, is placed in the mouth of the series' only Indigenous lawman and naturalized as the lore of "his people." Philip J. Deloria's *Playing Indian* (1998) anatomizes the settler habit of constituting American identity through imagined Indianness, which serves as the nation's authentic interior. *Twin Peaks* performs this habit while partly registering it. Hawk is the only character whose cosmological statements prove consistently accurate, and in TR 10–11 it is Hawk who decodes the map in Sheriff Truman's office, reading its symbols through his heritage and refusing to gloss one of them, a black fire (see 7.5). Frost's SH extends the Indigenous strand historically through the Nez Perce and the passage of the Lewis and Clark expedition, culminating in Meriwether Lewis's mysterious death in 1809.

The land is therefore a palimpsest. European esotericism overwrites an Indigenous cosmology, which is then pressed into service as authenticating ground. American horror has a trope for this unconscious, the house built on an "Indian burial ground" (*The Shining*, 1980; *Poltergeist*, 1982), and Ben Horne's Ghostwood development, a real-estate venture in a forest named for ghosts, literalizes it. The Lodges stand on extracted ground.

The owl belongs to the same palimpsest. The Giant's warning in TP 8 that the owls are not what they seem makes owls watchers. In numerous Indigenous North American traditions the owl portends death. The King James translators rendered the Hebrew night-creature *līlīt* of Isaiah 34:14 as "screech owl," and Athena's owl signified wisdom. The series' owl condenses vigilance, omen, and the predatory nocturnal feminine. Chapter 6 adds a fourth sense: the owl is the spectator.

The Dugpas and the Orientalist Archive 1.3

Windom Earle's late second-season sermon names the Dugpas as sorcerers who cultivate evil for its own sake and draw their power from the Black Lodge. Earle's Dugpas come from Theosophy. Blavatsky used the name of the Drukpa lineage of the Kagyu school, founded by Tsangpa Gyare in the twelfth century and still the state tradition of Bhutan, as a byword for black magic, opposing the "Red Caps" to the reformed "Yellow Caps" of the Gelug. Sectarian slander was thus rendered as cosmology, and it passed through occult fiction into the popular imagination.

Donald S. Lopez Jr.'s *Prisoners of Shangri-La* (1998) reconstructs this Western invention of a Tibet split between pure wisdom and sorcery, from Theosophy through W. Y. Evans-Wentz's *Tibetan Book of the Dead* (1927) to the fabricated memoirs of Lobsang Rampa. *Twin Peaks* reproduces both poles. Cooper occupies the benign pole: his dream of the Tibetan people's plight and the deductive method of thrown stones it taught him (TP 2), and his guidance of the dying Leland toward the light in phrases modeled on the *Bardo Thödol*'s instructions to the dying (TP 16). Earle's Dugpas occupy the malign pole. In one of its lines of descent, the white/black dualism of the Lodges derives from a Victorian Orientalist splitting of a living Buddhist culture into a good and an evil Tibet (Said 1978). The cosmology's chromatic dualism bears the scar of that operation.

The same archive supplied *The Return*'s tulpas. Alexandra David-Néel's *Mystiques et magiciens du Thibet* (1929) introduced the West to the *tulpa*, a phantom produced by sustained visualization, and recounted her own creation of a genial monk who grew sinister and independent and required months to dissolve. Refracted through Annie Besant and Leadbeater's *Thought-Forms* (1901), this narrative underwrites Dougie Jones and the Diane of TR 16, and Chapter 3 will read it as a theory of manufactured selfhood.

Frost's Secret History*: Rocketry, Thelema, and the Occult Republic* 1.4

SH adopts the form of a classified dossier compiled by an anonymous Archivist and annotated by the FBI agent Tamara Preston. It reconstructs American history as an occult palimpsest: the Lewis and Clark expedition; the career of Douglas Milford, which runs from the Kenneth Arnold sighting near Mount Rainier in June 1947, the event that gave the press the "flying saucer," through Roswell and Project Blue Book; and Jack Parsons, co-founder of the Jet Propulsion Laboratory, devotee of Aleister Crowley's Thelema, and celebrant with L. Ron Hubbard of the Babalon Working of 1946.

Frost's method treats the occult not as an alternative to American history but as its suppressed interior. Recent scholarship supports him. Jason Ā. Josephson-Storm's *The*

Myth of Disenchantment (2017) dismantles the Weberian narrative of modernity's progressive *Entzauberung*, showing that occultism flourished within and alongside the sciences, and Parsons, rocket engineer and Thelemic magician, is its emblem. Erik Davis's *TechGnosis* (1998) traces the mystical imagination that accompanies each new technology, and Pynchon's *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973) makes the V-2 a sacred technology of death. Frost's dossier belongs to this lineage: the history of American technoscience is the history of a magical operation whose door, opened in 1945–47, has not closed.

The dossier form is itself an epistemology. Its authority derives from redaction, annotation, and provenance; Frost's metaphysics is archival, forensic, and historical, and it believes in documents. Lynch's metaphysics, as Chapter 2 shows, believes in dreams.

1.5 *Holmes and the Spirit Photograph: Cooper as Doylean Synthesis*

Frost's first novel, *The List of Seven* (1993), makes Arthur Conan Doyle the hero of an occult thriller against a secret brotherhood. The choice is diagnostic. Doyle created literature's most influential embodiment of forensic rationality and spent his last decade as a militant Spiritualist who defended the Cottingley fairy photographs in *The Coming of the Fairies* (1922).

Cooper is the Doylean synthesis made flesh. He is Holmesian in his forensic precision, his catalogues of trivia, and his tape-recorded dispatches to an absent Diane, who inverts Watson by making the chronicler a silent addressee. He is Spiritualist in his reliance on dreams, giants, and thrown stones. His genealogy also includes Poe's Dupin, whose ratiocination is avowedly the faculty of a poet (1844), and Chesterton's Father Brown, who explains in "The Secret of Father Brown" (1927) that he solves murders by imagining himself into the murderer until he recognizes the murderer in himself. Father Brown's method is the Dweller's test: to know the killer, the detective must meet his own capacity for killing. Cooper's fate in the Lodge is the logical terminus of a detective tradition that grounds knowledge in self-recognition.

By TP 2 Cooper has become a medium in the Spiritualist sense, a channel through which the dead speak. By TR 3 he has become a medium in the technical sense, a current that passes through a wall socket. The pun that joins the séance to the circuit is the hinge on which this dissertation turns, and Part Three follows it.

CHAPTER TWO

II

The Spider and the Dreamer

Lynch's Vedāntic Ontology

LYNCH's contribution to the cosmology is not a second dualism but a monism that dissolves dualism from within. From 1973 until his death in January 2025, Lynch practiced Transcendental Meditation twice daily, and his late writings articulate a Vedāntic ontology in which every image, the darkest included, arises from and returns to a single field of consciousness. This chapter reconstructs that ontology, maps its fourfold topology onto *The Return*, shows that it entails an explicit refusal of the Romantic economy of suffering, and argues that the corpus is the product of a sustained dialectic between two metaphysics.

2.1 *Transcendental Meditation and the Unified Field*

Maharishi Mahesh Yogi (d. 2008) was a disciple of Swami Brahmananda Saraswati, Śaṅkarācārya of Jyotirmath, and Transcendental Meditation therefore descends institutionally from the monastic lineage of Śaṅkara's Advaita Vedānta. The technique uses a mantra to "transcend" discursive thought toward pure consciousness, which the Maharishi's "Science of Creative Intelligence," championed by the physicist John Hagelin, identified with the unified field of physics. As physics the identification is a category error. As poetics it is exact: it posits a single substrate beneath all appearances, from which images surface like fish. Lynch's *Catching the Big Fish* (2006) builds its theory of creativity on this figure. Small ideas swim in the shallows; the large ones live deep down, and the artist who would catch them must dive.

Lynch's book cites an Upaniṣadic saying that likens us to a spider weaving its life and moving along the web, and to a dreamer who dreams and then lives inside the dream. The paraphrase conflates the *Muṇḍaka Upaniṣad* (1.1.7), where the universe arises from the imperishable as a spider emits and withdraws its thread, with the *Bṛhadāraṇyaka* (2.1.20), where all worlds, gods, and beings issue from the self like a spider's filament. The dreamer clause recalls the *Bṛhadāraṇyaka*'s fourth chapter, in which the self in dream fashions chariots, roads, and joys out of itself, becoming its own light (*svayaṃ jyotiḥ*, 4.3.9–14).

In TR 14 Gordon Cole, played by Lynch, recounts a dream in which Monica Bellucci speaks the dreamer clause and then asks: "But who is the dreamer?" The question reprises the Advaitic method of self-inquiry (*ātma-vicāra*) that Ramana Maharshi taught through the question "Who am I?", whose function is to dissolve the questioner. The author, playing his own avatar, receives in a dream the question of who dreams the dream in which he appears. Chapter 9 pursues the Borgesian implication.

Two further Advaitic doctrines bear on the corpus. Śaṅkara treats the world as a superimposition (*adhyāsa*) upon *brahman*, the rope mistaken for a snake, so that the multiplicity of persons, doubles, and places is real as appearance and unreal as substance. Gauḍapāda's *Māṇḍūkya-kārikā* goes further. It likens waking to dream and teaches *ajātivāda*, the doctrine that nothing has ever been born. The doctrine generates a tension the corpus never resolves: if nothing originates, the elaborate cosmogony of TR 8 is itself a dream within the dream, and Lynch's nondualism quietly undermines the very origin myth his revival stages.

The Four States of the Māṇḍūkya *and the Topology of* The Return 2.2

The *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad*, twelve verses long, analyzes the syllable AUM into four quarters. Vaiśvānara, the waking state, is outward-knowing and enjoys gross objects; it is "common to all men." Taijasa, the dream state, is inward-knowing and enjoys subtle forms; its name means "the luminous." Prājña, deep sleep, is an undivided mass of cognition, made of bliss, described as the lord of all and the source and end of beings. The Fourth (*turīya*) is neither inward nor outward, unseen and ungraspable, the cessation of the world, peaceful and nondual. In the Upaniṣad's final verse it corresponds to the measureless silence that follows the sounded syllable.

The topology of *The Return* maps onto this scheme with a precision that this dissertation advances as a homology, not as a claim about intention.

1. **Vaiśvānara** is the world of the towns: Twin Peaks, Las Vegas, Buckhorn, Odessa. It is the realm of gross objects, commerce, insurance, and law, the world common to all.
2. **Taijasa** is the Red Room and its anteroom, the Waiting Room: subtle forms, inverted speech, doubles, a staged and lit interior. Cooper first enters it in a dream (TP 2), and it obeys dream-logic throughout.
3. **Prājña** is the undifferentiated zone of TR 3 and TR 8: the purple sea, the room of the eyeless Naido, the monochrome palace of the Fireman. It is prior to individuation and literally the "source and end of beings," since the Fireman's palace is where Laura's orb is emitted.
4. **Turīya** is never shown, because it cannot be. I propose that it appears only negatively, as the darkness that follows Laura's scream at the end of TR 18. The scream is the last sounded syllable of the corpus; what follows is the soundless Fourth.

This last proposition is synthetic, and Chapter 10 joins it to the media reading of the same moment as a short circuit. The two readings converge: the end of the broadcast and the awakening of the dreamer are one event.

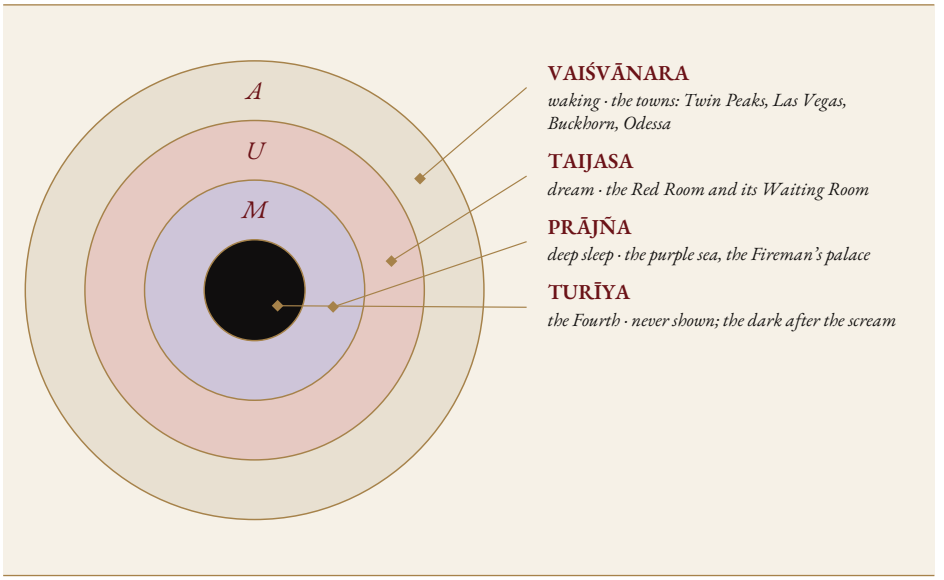


FIG. 2 *The four quarters of AUM in the Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad, mapped onto the topology of The Return. The Fourth is never shown; it appears only as the dark that follows the scream.*

2.3 *Against the Romance of Suffering*

The most consequential page in *Catching the Big Fish* is its rejection of the doctrine that the artist must suffer. Lynch argues that suffering diminishes creativity rather than feeding it, that one need not undergo anguish in order to depict it, and that negativity is like a suffocating rubber clown suit that falls away through transcending. The target is the Romantic economy of productive pain. Keats's letter of April 1819 calls the world a "vale of Soul-making," in which troubles school an intelligence into a soul. Nietzsche's *Twilight of the Idols* (1888) holds that what does not kill me makes me stronger. Behind both stands the Christian-penitential valuation of suffering as merit.

Lynch's position is, in the terms of this dissertation, **anti-algophagic**. Suffering is not nourishment, neither for the soul nor for art. It follows that the Black Lodge is, among other things, a satire of the Romantic studio: its inhabitants believe pain is food, they feed on it, and they grow fat on it, as BOB's grin attests. Garmonbozia turns Keats's vale into a feeding trough. The apparent paradox of a blissful meditator who made some of the darkest images in American cinema dissolves once depiction is distinguished from consumption. To show suffering is not to eat it; what matters is the mode of attention. Chapter 10 develops this distinction into a theory of two spectatorships.

A countercurrent must be acknowledged. Lynch spoke often of karma, and Max Weber's sociology of religion judged the doctrine of karma the most consistent theodicy history had produced. Karma renders suffering intelligible as consequence, and intelligi-

bility is a mild form of digestion. When Cooper guides the dying Leland toward the light in TP 16, the scene extends a karmic and Tibetan mercy to a man who had raped his daughter for years and murdered her, along with Teresa Banks, Maddy Ferguson, and, in a hospital bed, Jacques Renault, and many viewers found that mercy troubling. The corpus will later withdraw this consolation, and the withdrawal is the subject of Chapter 10.

The Twin Peaks of Metaphysics: Frost's Dualism, Lynch's Nonduality 2.4

The collaboration is a dialectic between two metaphysics. Frost's is dualist (Böhme, Blavatsky, the Manichaean cosmos), historicist (the dossier), forensic (the document), and conspiratorial (the occult interior of American history). Lynch's is nondualist (Advaita, the unified field), oneiric (the dream), intuitive (ideas as fish), and painterly (the image before the word).

The textual history confirms the alternation. FWWM, scripted by Lynch and Robert Engels without Frost, intensifies the mystical and nondual register: the town's comic plurality contracts into one girl's passion, and the film ends with an angel. Frost's solo novels, SH and FD, intensify the historical and dualist register. *The Return*, cowritten and directed entirely by Lynch, stages their encounter, and Part 8 is its meeting point, where Frost's 1945 meets Lynch's abstraction.

The two summits that overlook the town, named in the series' lore White Tail and Blue Pine, emblematize the dyad. The name of the hero completes the emblem: a *dale* is a valley, and Dale Cooper is the low ground where two slopes meet. It is fitting that *The Return* splits him in two, into Mr. C and Dougie Jones, for a valley is defined by its two sides. Heraclitus supplies the formula for a dialectic that is sustained rather than resolved. Men do not understand, he says, how what is at variance agrees with itself, a back-stretched harmony (*palintropos harmoníē*) like that of the bow and the lyre (DK B51). *Twin Peaks* is such a harmony: its tension is its music.

PART TWO

Structures

III · THE TWIN AND THE TULPA
IV · THE FOUNDING MURDER
V · GARMONBOZIA

CHAPTER THREE

III

The Twin and the Tulpa

Doubles, Faces, and the Manufactured Self

THE double in *Twin Peaks* is not chiefly a psychological figure, as it was for Rank and Freud, but an ontological and economic one. Doubles in this corpus are summoned, manufactured, insured, and consumed, and by *The Return* they proliferate to the point of ontological inflation. This chapter traces the Romantic and psychoanalytic double into the series, reads the tulpa as a theory of the self as product, and identifies the face as the surface on which the two Lodges are inscribed.

The Doppelgänger Tradition from Jean Paul to Rank 3.1

Jean Paul coined *Doppeltgänger* in *Siebenkäs* (1796–97), and the figure ran through E. T. A. Hoffmann's *The Devil's Elixirs* (1815–16), James Hogg's *Confessions of a Justified Sinner* (1824), Poe's "William Wilson" (1839), Dostoevsky's *The Double* (1846), Stevenson's *Jekyll and Hyde* (1886), and Wilde's *Dorian Gray* (1890). Otto Rank's *Der Doppelgänger* (1914; expanded 1925) gave the tradition its theory. The double, Rank argued, began as an insurance against the destruction of the ego, an energetic denial of death in the form of an immortal soul, and later reversed its sign to become death's harbinger. Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) adopted the thesis whole.

The Return literalizes Rank with a bureaucratic wit worthy of Kafka. Mr. C, the double released in TP 29, manufactures a second double, Dougie Jones, as a decoy to be drawn back into the Lodge in his place. The double is quite literally an insurance policy

against return, and Dougie Jones sells insurance. Around this joke the series multiplies its pairs: Laura and her cousin Maddy, both played by Sheryl Lee; Leland and BOB; Cooper and Mr. C; Diane and her tulpa; Naido and Diane; Dale and Richard; Laura and Carrie Page. Each pair reproduces Rank's reversal: what was meant to protect a self from death ends by carrying death into it.

3.2 *Shadow, Mirror, Threshold*

Jung's *Aion* (1951) defines the shadow as the moral problem that tests the whole personality: no one becomes conscious of it without considerable moral effort, since it requires recognizing the dark aspects of the personality as present and real. Hawk's warning about imperfect courage is a Jungian maxim in Theosophical dress. Cooper enters the Lodge in TP 29 not from equanimity but from love for Annie and guilt over Caroline. In Buddhist terms his entry is fueled by attachment (*upādāna*), and attachment is precisely what the Lodge knows how to feed on.

The mirror is the series' threshold. Its first image after the credits is Josie Packard at her vanity, and its last image in 1991 is Cooper's double driving his head into a bathroom mirror, which returns not his face but BOB's. Lacan's mirror stage (1949) describes the ego as an alienated imago, a unity borrowed from a reflection. The finale of TP 29 shatters that imago and reveals behind it not a deeper self but a possessor. Leland's reflections had already shown BOB (TP 14), so that the series' mirrors consistently function as screens on which the possessing agency becomes visible. Chapter 6 develops the equation between mirror and screen.

Hegel's Jena lectures of 1805–06 describe the subject itself as a "night of the world": an empty nothing that holds, in phantasmagoric representations, a bloody head that suddenly shoots up here and a white figure that appears there and as suddenly vanishes, a night one glimpses on looking into another's eyes. Slavoj Žižek (1999) made the passage central to his account of the subject, and the Red Room realizes it as set design. Its apparitions arrive and vanish without transition, and in TR 3 Major Briggs appears to Cooper as a disembodied head floating in the dark, pronouncing the words *Blue Rose*. The Lodge is the night of the world given walls.

The Tulpa as Commodity: Dougie Jones and the Industrial Self 3.3

The tulpa enters the corpus through Alexandra David-Néel (1929) and Besant and Leadbeater's *Thought-Forms* (1901), and *The Return* stages its logic as a Blue Rose problem. In Tammy Preston's reconstruction of the Lois Duffy case, a murdered woman's double declares herself like the blue rose before vanishing, and Tammy concludes that the double was conjured, not born. A blue rose does not occur in nature; the emblem of the Blue Rose task force is therefore artifice itself. When MIKE, examining the reconstituted Dougie in TR 16, observes that someone manufactured him for a purpose that is now fulfilled, the verb is exact. The tulpa is a product.

Cooper's response is the most ethically vertiginous act in the revival. He asks MIKE to make another, supplies a strand of his hair, and the Lodge returns a new Dougie to Janey-E and Sonny Jim. A husband and father is manufactured to fill a family's need. Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) is the indispensable comparison. Its ocean manufactures "visitors" from the scientists' memories, and Kelvin's visitor, a copy of his dead wife Harey, tries to destroy herself once she understands she is a copy. The tragedy of the tulpa is self-knowledge. In TR 16 the tulpa Diane announces that she is not herself and vanishes, leaving in the Red Room only a golden seed.

That seed deserves comment. The Stoics held that matter is organized by *logoi spermatikoi*, seminal reasons; alchemy held that gold is matter perfected. The Lodge reduces a manufactured person to a golden seed and a metonymic fragment of hair, a formula for production that is at once Stoic, alchemical, and industrial.

Dougie himself is the series' satire of *homo economicus*. He is pure receptivity: he repeats the last words spoken to him, gravitates toward coffee and cherry pie, wins jackpot after jackpot at the Silver Mustang, exposes an insurance fraud by doodling on case files, and is loved by his family more than the man he replaced. In late capitalism the empty self is the most successful self. Lynch's lifelong aesthetic of the factory, from the industrial landscape of *Eraserhead* (1977) to *Industrial Symphony No. 1* (1990), finds its theological completion here: the Lodge is a factory of selves.

3.4 *White Wall, Black Hole: The Face as Lodge*

Deleuze and Guattari's *A Thousand Plateaus* (1980) describes the face as the product of an abstract machine of faciality, a "white wall/black hole system": a white wall of signifiance on which signs are inscribed and black holes of subjectivity into which consciousness and passion sink. *The Return* stages both components as literal anatomy. In TR 2 Laura opens her face like a mask and white light pours from it. In TR 14, in a roadside bar, Sarah Palmer removes hers before a trucker who has been harassing her and exposes a black void in which fragments float, a hand and a grinning mouth among them; when the face is back in place, she kills him with a bite to the throat. The two Lodges are the two components of the faciality machine. Laura is white wall; Sarah, possessed by the force the revival will call Judy, is black hole. And the black hole eats: Judy's first open act in the revival is a killing by mouth, the algophagic organ made literal.

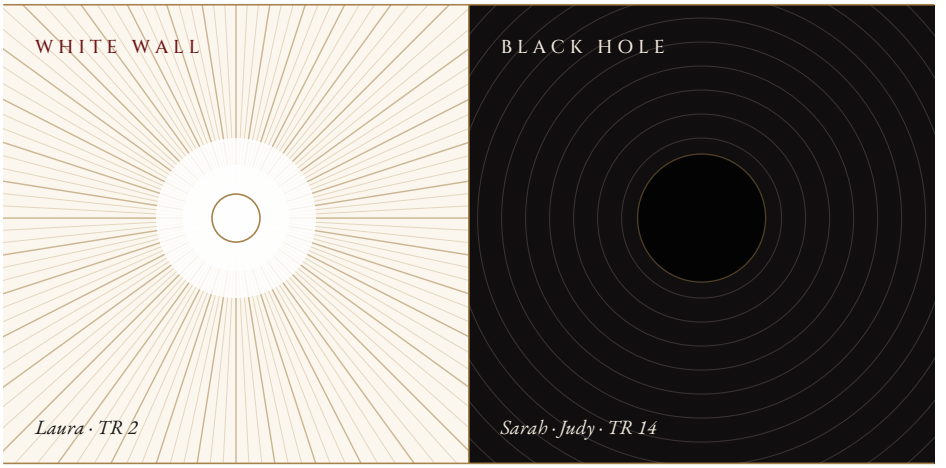


FIG. 3 *White wall, black hole: Deleuze and Guattari's machine of faciality, staged as anatomy. Laura's face opens onto light (TR 2); Sarah's opens onto a void that eats (TR 14).*

Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) understands the face as the epiphany of the Other, whose nakedness issues the command not to kill. The revival's violence against faces should be read against that ethic. BOB's face is an anti-face, a grimace of appetite without alterity. In TR 18 Diane covers Cooper's face with her hands while they make love, because the face before her has also been the face of the double who raped her (TR 16): she cannot bear to face it. Lynch's acknowledged admiration for Francis Bacon (Rodley 1997) supplies the painterly genealogy of this defaced humanity, the smeared heads and screaming popes of *Study after Velázquez's Portrait of Pope Innocent X* (1953). Chapter 10 returns to Bacon's scream.

CHAPTER FOUR

IV

The Founding Murder

Girard, the Pageant, and the Pharmakon

Twin Peaks is a sacrificial community organized around a murdered girl, but it inverts René Girard's model. There is no unanimous murder, only a distributed appetite whose violence is condensed in the father and mythologized as BOB. *Fire Walk With Me* then performs what Girard calls revelation, telling the founding murder from the side of the victim, and the persecuting community of its audience refused it.

Mimesis and Unanimity in a Lumber Town 4.1

Girard's theory, elaborated from *Deceit, Desire, and the Novel* (1961) through *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) and *The Scapegoat* (1982), holds that desire is mimetic, that mimetic rivalry escalates into a crisis of undifferentiation, and that communities resolve the crisis by converging upon a single victim. The victim is then sacralized by a double transference: blamed for the disorder, credited with the peace that follows the killing.

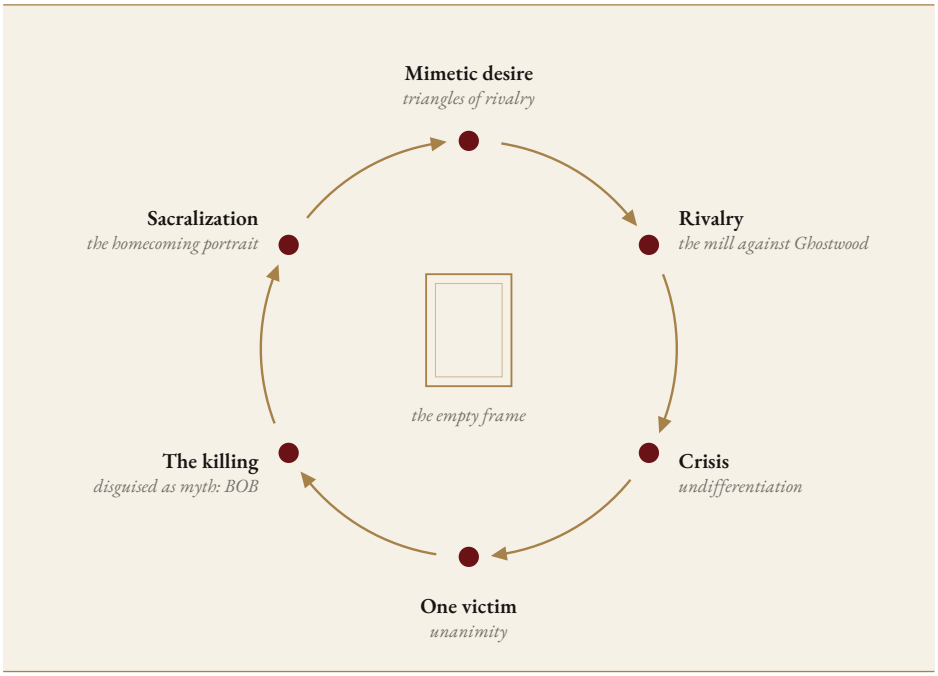


FIG. 4 *The sacrificial wheel: Girard's cycle of mimetic crisis and its resolution upon a single victim. At its centre, the empty frame of the homecoming portrait.*

The town of the pilot is in latent mimetic crisis. Erotic triangles interlock (James, Laura, Bobby; Bobby, Shelly, Leo; Ed, Norma, Nadine; Josie, Truman, Catherine, Ben), economic rivalry pits the Packard sawmill against the Ghostwood development, and doubles shadow every relationship. Laura's death polarizes the town's energies onto one image. Her funeral in TP 3 is a Girardian rite in grotesque miniature: Leland hurls himself onto the coffin, which jerks up and down on its mechanical lift, and James and Bobby come to blows.

Yet the investigation reveals that no single agent consumed Laura. Ben Horne owned the brothel where she, a minor, was prostituted, recruited like other girls through the perfume counter of his own department store, and he had a sexual relationship with her; Jacques Renault and Leo Johnson exploited her in a circuit of cocaine and sex, and on her last night Renault bound her in his cabin; Bobby sold her cocaine; Dr. Jacoby kept her tapes; Harold Smith kept her diary. The appetite was distributed across the town, and the father, who had raped her since she was twelve, is its delegated executor. Girard's account of myth as "persecution text" explains BOB's function: myth conceals collective violence by projecting it onto a monstrous agent. Cooper exposes this function in TP 16 when he asks Truman whether it would be easier, or any more comforting, to believe that a man would rape and murder his own daughter. Albert answers with a line from *Julius Caesar*: perhaps BOB is simply the evil that men do, the evil that lives after them.

The series nevertheless insists that BOB is real. It holds Girard's demystification and Theosophy's ontology in suspension, and the suspension is the point. *Twin Peaks* is a persecution text read from inside, where the reader cannot decide whether the monster is the community's alibi or the community's truth. Girard's late *I See Satan Fall Like Lightning* (1999) closes the gap from the other side, interpreting Satan as the principle of mimetic contagion that possesses communities and passes from host to host. BOB, who migrates from Leland into Cooper's double and grins from every available mirror, is Girard's Satan with a face.

Miss Twin Peaks: The Pageant as Sacrificial Selection 4.2

The series' penultimate episode, TP 28, makes the sacrificial mechanism explicit. Windom Earle plans to abduct the winner of the Miss Twin Peaks pageant to the Black Lodge. The winner is Annie Blackburn, a former novice whose speech defends the endangered forest against development. The forest's defender is sacrificed to the forest's Lodge. Earle's earlier chess game with Cooper, in which each captured piece corresponds to a murder, had already reconceived sacrifice as a gambit and the queen as the piece most worth taking. Laura's homecoming portrait, the image the whole series mourns, is the product of the same mechanism: the pageant manufactures the town's emblem, and the emblem is the victim.

James George Frazer's *The Golden Bough* (1890) opens with the King of the Wood at Nemi, the priest who guards a sacred tree in Diana's grove until a successor slays him and takes his place. Glastonbury Grove, a circle of twelve sycamores, is where Earle, Cooper's former partner and predecessor, and Cooper, his successor, meet at the Lodge's threshold. The structure of the *rex nemorensis* is intact. That the goddess of Nemi was Diana is a coincidence that a Lodge-theoretic hermeneutics may notice without being obliged to explain.

Fire Walk With Me *as Gospel Revelation* 4.3

Girard's *Things Hidden Since the Foundation of the World* (1978) argues that the Passion narratives are the first texts to tell the founding murder from the victim's side. They reveal the victim's innocence and the persecutors' lie, and thereby expose the mechanism that myth conceals. FWWM is structured as such a revelation. It opens with an axe destroying a television set, then narrates Laura's last seven days from within, a Holy Week of paternal rape, addiction, and terror. It suppresses almost entirely the town's comic plurality, the quirky ensemble that had made the series consumable, and ends with an angel. When Laura tells Cooper in TR 2 that she is dead yet lives, she echoes the Johannine promise of resurrection (John 11:25).

The film's notoriously hostile reception at Cannes in 1992 and its commercial failure in the United States admit a Girardian reading. Audiences wanted the myth, a charming town haunted by a monster, and were given the revelation: a respectable father's rape of his daughter, told from inside the daughter's experience. The persecuting community did not want the scapegoat to speak. The film's slow critical rehabilitation, culminating in *The Return*'s treatment of FWWM as the indispensable key to the entire corpus, is the slow work of revelation upon a resistant audience.

4.4 *The Persecuting Audience: Folk Horror and the American Grove*

The literary genealogy of this structure is American and arboreal. In Hawthorne's "Young Goodman Brown" (1835), a forest sabbath reveals the town's most respectable citizens as the devil's congregation; One Eyed Jacks, across the border in the woods, performs the same revelation for the Hornes. Shirley Jackson's "The Lottery" (1948) stages a village's annual killing as civic routine. *The Wicker Man* (1973) lures an investigating Christian policeman to an island where he becomes the sacrifice, as Cooper the investigator becomes the Lodge's prisoner for twenty-five years. Stephen King's *It* (1986), published four years before the pilot, imagines a small town whose ancient resident wakes every twenty-seven years to feed on the fear of children while the adults forget. It is the closest literary analogue to garmonbozia before *Twin Peaks*, and its cycle anticipates Laura's promise to see Cooper again in twenty-five years.

British weird fiction supplies the closest literary analogue to Laura's diary. In Arthur Machen's "The White People" (1904), a girl's secret notebook records how, from early childhood, her nurse initiated her into a hidden practice in the woods, and the story's frame argues that true evil is not a social offense but an ontological one, an attempt to enter another order of being by forbidden means. Machen's prologue states the Lodge's moral theory in advance, and the girl's notebook is the prototype of SDLP, which records from Laura's twelfth year a violation she could name only as BOB. Algernon Blackwood's "The Willows" (1907) and "The Wendigo" (1910) give the wilderness itself a predatory numinosity, the presence Sheriff Truman describes to Cooper in the first season as something very strange in these old woods, there for as long as anyone can remember.

Adam Scovell's *Folk Horror* (2017) identifies a chain of landscape, isolation, skewed moral belief, and a culminating happening or summoning. *Twin Peaks* is American folk horror on network television, with the logging forest as landscape, the border town as isolation, the Lodge lore as belief, and the murder as the happening.

Two further concepts sharpen the analysis. Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) describes bare life, which may be killed without the killing counting as sacrifice. From the age of twelve Laura was such a life, raped by her father with impunity inside a respectable house and prostituted as a minor in a brothel owned by the town's leading

businessman; only her death made her sacred. The passage from bare life to sacred victim is the town's alibi. Jacques Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) recovers the double sense of *pharmakon*, remedy and poison, and its kinship with *pharmakos*, the scapegoat, in Plato's critique of writing. Laura's diary is a pharmakon in exactly this sense: the dangerous supplement that both reveals and conceals, whose keeper, Harold Smith, takes his own life after an attempt to steal it from him, and whose missing pages Hawk finds in TR 9 hidden in a bathroom stall door of the sheriff's station, a door whose manufacturer's label bears the name Nez Perce. The pages report a dream message, that the good Dale is in the Lodge and cannot leave. Writing preserves the victim's testimony and delays it for twenty-five years; the remedy and the poison are the same text.

CHAPTER FIVE

V

Garmonbozia

Toward an Algophagic Ontology

GARMONBOZIA is the master-concept of the corpus: a single word for suffering's convertibility into food. This chapter formalizes algophagy by reading the creamed corn through five economies, the sacramental, the mythic, the political, the mystical, and the psychoanalytic, and closes by identifying the counter-economy of nourishment that the series sets against it.

Creamed Corn: The Phenomenology of a Sacrament 5.1

The substance appears first as a conjuring trick. In the second season, a masked boy, the grandson of Mrs. Tremond, makes the creamed corn on Donna's Meals on Wheels tray vanish from the plate and reappear in his own hands. FWWM supplies the name and the gloss. After Laura's death, in the Red Room, the Arm demands from BOB all of his garmonbozia, and the subtitles translate: pain and sorrow.

The choice of creamed corn is not arbitrary whimsy. Creamed corn is pale, mashed, and infantile, the texture of baby food. It is industrial, a canned staple of the mid-century American pantry. Above all it looks already eaten. Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) locates the abject in food that disgusts because it blurs the boundary between what is outside the body and what has passed through it. Garmonbozia is abject in exactly this sense: pain that has already passed through one stomach on its way to another. The Lodge's economy is one of shares and debts. BOB harvests; the Arm claims his por-

tion; the spirits convene in a room above a convenience store (FWWM; TR 8; TR 15), the consumer society's sanctum.

The neologism admits a paronomasia its authors surely did not intend. Russian *garmon'* names a folk accordion, from "harmony"; Polish *Bozia* is the nursery diminutive for God. To a Slavic ear the food of demons sounds out something like "the little God's harmony," a children's hymn. The resonance is offered as a homology, and it is apt: algophagy always presents itself as a harmony in which someone's pain has been made to serve a larger music.

5.2 *Wood and Maize: A Mesoamerican Homology*

The *Popol Vuh* of the K'iche' Maya, set down in alphabetic K'iche' in the sixteenth century and preserved through Francisco Ximénez's copy of about 1701, narrates the gods' successive attempts to make beings who would remember and praise them (trans. Tedlock 1985; rev. 1996). A being of mud dissolves. Effigies carved of wood follow: they speak and multiply, but they have no blood, no hearts or minds, and no memory of their makers. A flood destroys them, and their own grinding stones, griddles, pots, and dogs rise up against them; their remnant become the monkeys of the forest. Only on the third attempt do the gods succeed, shaping human flesh from yellow and white maize.

The homology with *Twin Peaks* is exact on both terms. The Woodsmen, soot-blackened, mindless, incantatory, and mechanically lethal, are the wooden people returned. Garmonbozia, served as creamed corn, makes the Lodge's food the very substance from which, in K'iche' cosmogony, human flesh is made. The Lodge eats humanity in its sacramental form. Beneath the sacrament lies a cannibal structure, an inverted Eucharist in which the bread is not the god's body offered to humans but human pain offered to gods. The Mexica theology of sacrifice as repayment of a debt, *nextlahualli*, supplies the political form of this relation: the gods who sacrificed themselves to set the sun in motion are owed hearts and blood. The Lodge's spirits are creditors.

Vampire Capital, Accursed Share 5.3

Marx's *Capital* (1867) describes capital as dead labour that, vampire-like, lives only by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks. The economy of the town is extractive from its first frame: timber, the sawmill, the hotel, the brothel. Ben Horne's fortune rests partly on the prostitution of teenage girls at One Eyed Jacks, recruited through the perfume counter of his own department store, so that the town's leading shop is literally the intake of its brothel; Leland Palmer, Ben's lawyer, is the hinge between the town's legal economy and its sexual one. *The Return* moves the economy to Las Vegas and modernizes it. There are slot machines at the Silver Mustang, Lucky 7 Insurance, whose trade is the actuarial pricing of injury and death, and Rancho Rosa, a subdivision of foreclosed and abandoned houses in the aftermath of 2008. Algophagy is also political economy: the conversion of suffering into value.

Georges Bataille's *The Accursed Share* (1949) provides the counter-concept. Every system receives more energy than it needs; the surplus must be spent, either gloriously, in sacrifice, festival, luxury, and art, or catastrophically, in war. The sun is the model of expenditure without return. The Lodge is the nightmare of the restricted economy: accumulation, debt, and hoarding, condensed in the Arm's demand for *all* of his garmonbozia. The Fireman's golden emanation in TR 8 is its opposite, a solar gift. Bataille wrote with the atomic bomb in view, a fact Chapter 7 will make decisive.

Simone Weil's essay "The Love of God and Affliction" (1942) describes the phenomenology of the extracted subject. Affliction (*malheur*) uproots a life, is anonymous, and stamps the soul with slavery. Its most terrible effect is to make the afflicted complicit in their own affliction through self-contempt. FWWM depicts this effect without moralism: Laura's cocaine, her prostitution at One Eyed Jacks, and her cruelty to James and Donna are affliction's work upon its host. Weil's complicity names an inward effect of affliction, not a share of guilt. The agents of the harm are adults whom the corpus names: the father who raped her, the men who exploited her, and the businessman whose brothel profited from her.

Ray Bradbury's *Something Wicked This Way Comes* (1962) gives the economy its American fairground. Cooger and Dark's carnival subsists on the misery it cultivates in a small town, and the librarian Charles Halloway defeats Mr. Dark with laughter. Laura's laughter through tears before the angel at the end of FWWM belongs to the same counter-magic.

5.4 *Shells and Phantoms: Kabbalistic, Manichaean, and Psychoanalytic Economies*

The Lurianic Kabbalah of sixteenth-century Safed, transmitted by Hayyim Vital, teaches that creation began with divine contraction (*tzimtzum*), that the vessels meant to hold the divine light shattered (*shevirat ha-kelim*), and that sparks of holiness fell into husks or shells (*kelipot*). The shells live on the light they imprison. Repair (*tikkun*) consists in raising the sparks through right action, and Hasidic teaching extended the doctrine to eating: a meal taken with proper intention (*kavvanah*) liberates the sparks hidden in food. Manichaeism held an analogous doctrine, in which the ritual meals of the Elect released particles of light trapped in plants, a belief Augustine mocks in the *Confessions* (III.10) with the image of a fig that weeps when plucked. Two economies of eating thus confront each other: the meal that liberates light and the meal that feeds the shells. The Lodge feeds the shells.

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok's *The Shell and the Kernel* (1978) arrives at the same image from psychoanalysis. Abraham's concept of the phantom designates a parent's unspoken secret transmitted into the unconscious of a child, so that what haunts us is not the dead but the gaps left in us by the secrets of others. The crypt is the intrapsychic tomb that houses an unmourned object. BOB is a transgenerational phantom in this precise sense. By Leland's own account in TP 16, BOB came to him as a boy at his grandfather's summer house at Pearl Lakes, and Leland narrates that entry in the vocabulary of a child's violation. The violated child becomes the father who violates, and BOB passes down the paternal line toward Laura. The Red Room is the crypt. *The Return* adds a maternal phantom: the girl of 1956, widely read as the young Sarah Palmer, who swallows the frog-moth in TR 8 and who will become the vessel of Judy. Laura is the crypt of two parental possessions. That Abraham and Torok's shell (*écorce*) and Luria's shell (*kelipah*) name the same structure is the strongest convergence in this chapter: a husk that lives on the light it hides.

The Return extends the chain by a generation. Mr. C, the double through whom BOB acts for twenty-five years, rapes Diane (TR 16), and according to Frost's FD he raped Audrey Horne while she lay in a coma after the bank explosion of TP 29. The son conceived, Richard Horne, runs down and kills a child and drives away (TR 6), then attacks Miriam Sullivan, the schoolteacher who saw it, and his grandmother Sylvia Horne (TR 10). His father finally consumes him: in TR 16 Mr. C sends Richard onto a rock at the coordinates he is seeking, where Richard is destroyed in a burst of electricity, and bids his son goodbye. Audrey herself spends most of the revival confined to a looping argument in an unexplained room, and her last appearance is a cry to be let out, cut to a white room and a mirror (TR 16). The phantom has become a lineage: possession transmitted as rape, rape reproduced as violence, and the father at last devouring the son.

The Diner and the Angel: Counter-Nourishment 5.5

The series opposes to garmonbozia a complete counter-economy of nourishment. The Double R Diner, its name a doubled letter, is the town's secular sanctuary: Norma's pies, Cooper's coffee, and Cooper's counsel to Truman to give himself a present every day, unplanned and unearned. In *The Return*, Dougie's helpless delight in coffee and cherry pie and the Mitchum brothers' gifts of food reconstitute the same communion in Las Vegas. Eating here is the liberating meal.

The theology of this counter-economy is hung on Laura's bedroom wall. A devotional print shows an angel attending children at a table. In FWWM the angel vanishes from the picture, an image of grace withdrawn, and at the film's end an angel appears to Laura in the Red Room. The Psalmist's phrase, that man did eat angels' food (Psalm 78:25), names the alternative to garmonbozia: nourishment that is given rather than extracted. The moral universe of *Twin Peaks* is organized, finally, by modes of eating.

The structure this chapter has traced can be stated in a single table. Each register extracts suffering from a particular subject, converts it into a transmissible form, and delivers it to a consumer; each also generates, in the course of the corpus, a counter-form that resists consumption.

Register	*Suffering extracted from*	*Transmissible form*	*Consumed by*	*Inedible counter-form*
Occult	the possessed host	garmonbozia, served as creamed corn	BOB, the Arm, the Lodge	the ring that makes Laura unpossessable (FWWM)
Social	the sacred victim	the homecoming portrait	the town and its rites	FWWM's revelation from the victim's side
Familial	the daughter	the family secret, transmitted as phantom	the father; the maternal line through Judy	the whisper that names the father (TP 2, TP 16)
Epistemic	the case	clues, files, the dead girl's image	the detective's melancholic devotion	the whisper withheld from the audience (TR 2, TR 18)
Technological	the image	the electrical signal and the broadcast	the audience and the apparatus	the scream and the blackout (TR 18)

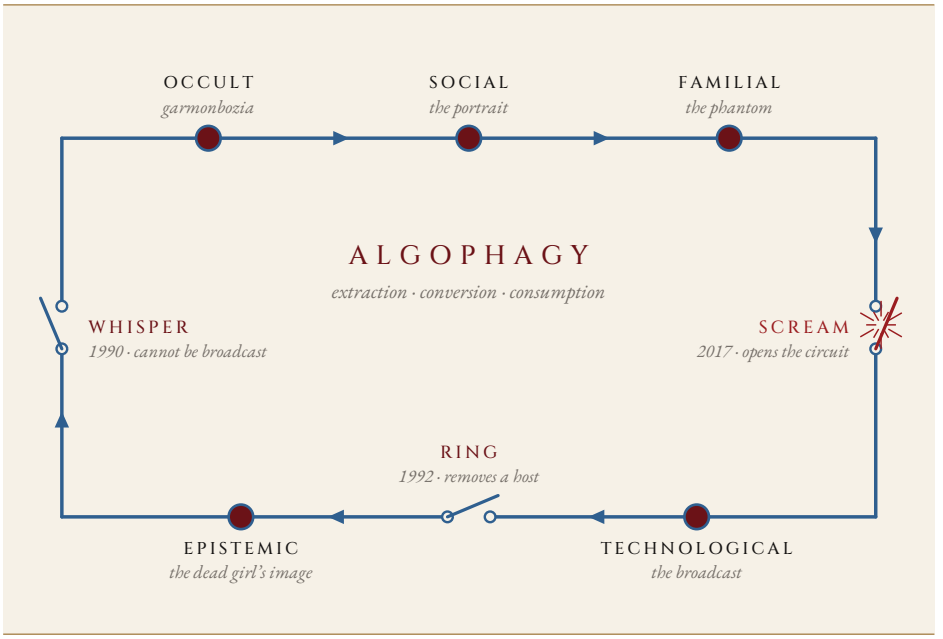


FIG. 5 *The algophagic circuit. Suffering is extracted, converted, and consumed across five registers; the corpus's three inedible forms act as breakers, and the last of them, the scream, opens the circuit for good.*

PART THREE

Media

VI · THE LODGE AS RELAY
VII · TRINITY

CHAPTER SIX

VI

The Lodge as Relay

Electricity and the Spectral Medium

THE Lodges are not places but relays, switching stations in a circuit that is at once electrical and theological, and the Red Room is a composite portrait of analog media seen from the inside. This chapter reconstructs the spiritual history of electricity the series inherits, decomposes the Red Room into its media components, reads the apparatuses of *The Return*, and defines the Gnostic melodrama.

From Animal Magnetism to the Spirit Telegraph 6.1

The spiritualization of electricity is as old as its harnessing. Franz Anton Mesmer's *Mémoire* (1779) proposed an invisible fluid that healers could channel through iron rods immersed in a tub, the *baquet*, and a royal commission of 1784 that included Franklin and Lavoisier attributed its effects to imagination. Swedenborg's *Heaven and Hell* (1758) had already mapped a spirit world of correspondences. When Samuel Morse inaugurated the telegraph on 24 May 1844, the first official message was a verse from Numbers (23:23): "What hath God wrought." Four years later the Fox sisters' rappings at Hydesville were promptly called a "spiritual telegraph." Éliphas Lévi's astral light (1854–56) and Blavatsky's *ākāśa* supplied the medium a metaphysics. Edison spoke in 1920 of an apparatus for communicating with the dead, and Friedrich Jürgenson (1959) and Konstantīns Raudive (*Breakthrough*, 1971) claimed to record the voices of the dead on magnetic tape.

Media theory has made this history its object. Jeffrey Sconce (2000) shows that each new electronic medium was imagined as a portal to disembodied presence. Friedrich Kittler (1986) argues that the realm of the dead is as extensive as a culture's capacities for storage and transmission. John Durham Peters (1999) reads communication itself as the dream of angelic transmission. Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993) named hauntology, and Derrida had earlier remarked, in Ken McMullen's film *Ghost Dance* (1983), that cinema is the art of letting ghosts return. Mark Fisher's *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016) gives Lynch a chapter titled "Curtains and Holes."

Twin Peaks inherits this history as iconography. Power lines hum over the town; utility pole No. 6 presides over a trailer park in FWWM and, in TR 6, over the hit-and-run in which Richard Horne runs down a child and drives away, as a golden light rises from the boy's body toward the humming wires; lights strobe when the Lodge draws near; and in the meeting above the convenience store in FWWM, the word *electricity* is pronounced like an incantation. Thomas Pynchon's *Vineland*, published in January 1990, three months before the pilot, imagines Thanatoids, souls suspended in karmic limbo who watch television without cease. The televisual afterlife was in the air.

6.2 *The Red Room as Media-Archaeological Composite*

Decomposed into its elements, the Red Room is an assemblage of five media primitives.

1. **The curtain** is the proscenium of theatre and cinema. Lynch's work returns to it obsessively: the stage of the Lady in the Radiator in *Eraserhead*, the blue velvet behind the credits of *Blue Velvet*, and Club Silencio in *Mulholland Drive* (2001), whose master of ceremonies announces that there is no band and that everything is a recording.
2. **The chevron floor**, a black-and-white zigzag already present in *Eraserhead*, resembles an oscillographic trace, the sawtooth sweep that drives the raster of a cathode-ray tube. The floor is the signal made visible.
3. **The strobe** is flicker, the intermittency of cinematic projection and the refresh of the television screen.
4. **Reversed speech** was produced by having actors speak their lines phonetically backward and then reversing the recording. The Lodge speaks in the grammar of analog tape. Chion's *acousmêtre*, the voice whose source is not seen (1982), describes the Lodge's sonic regime and BOB's offscreen voice in particular.
5. **The furniture**, armchairs, floor lamps, side tables, and a classical Venus, is that of a mid-century living room, the domestic space in which television was received.

The Red Room is the television apparatus seen from inside: stage, signal, flicker, tape, and living room. This resolves the asymmetry identified in Chapter 1. Television can

show the Black Lodge because the Black Lodge is television. The White Lodge, which is a cinema of projected light, becomes visible only when the corpus becomes cinema, in TR 8. The Giant's warning that the owls are not what they seem acquires its fourth sense here. The owls are watchers, and the watchers are not innocent: the owl is the spectator.

Television can show the Black Lodge because the Black Lodge is television.

Lynch made the equation explicit in *Rabbits* (2002), whose episodes he later folded into *Inland Empire* (2006): a sitcom set in a dim living room, its rabbit-headed occupants trading non sequiturs that a laugh track greets at the wrong moments. The sitcom, the most domestic of television forms, becomes a Lodge simply by being slowed down and watched.

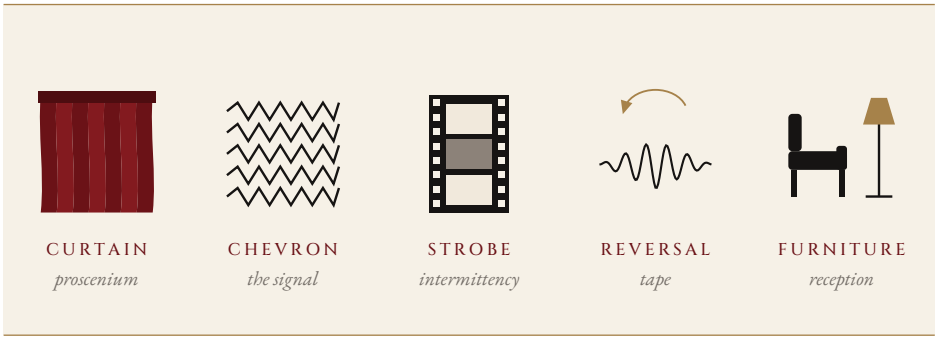


FIG. 6 *The Red Room decomposed into five media primitives: proscenium, signal, intermittency, tape, and the living room in which television was received.*

The Glass Box and the Socket 6.3

The Return opens with an allegory of spectatorship. In a Manhattan loft, an anonymous billionaire's apparatus consists of an empty glass box monitored by cameras. A young man, Sam Colby, is paid to watch it and to change its memory cards. When he and Tracey stop watching and begin to make love, a figure the credits name the Experiment materializes in the box, breaks through, and kills them both (TR 1). The box is a screen. Surveillance is invocation: the apparatus summons the entity it monitors. The watchers are punished, and the gaze is implicated from the first scene.

The socket completes the allegory. In TR 3 Cooper falls through a succession of spaces, meets the eyeless Naido, passes into an electrical socket, and emerges from an outlet

in Rancho Rosa while Dougie is drawn back into the Red Room. In TR 15 Dougie watches *Sunset Boulevard* (1950) on television. Hearing the name Gordon Cole, a Paramount functionary in Wilder's film and the name Lynch took for his own FBI character, he crawls to a wall socket with a fork and electrocutes himself. In TR 16 Cooper wakes. Wilder's film is narrated by a dead man floating in a swimming pool, and its heroine, a silent star destroyed by sound, insists on the primacy of faces. Cooper is resurrected by household current and by a dead man's film, and the author's alias, broadcast, summons the hero back to himself.

The Return is an encyclopedia of media. The Fireman listens to a gramophone (TR 1); Phillip Jeffries has become a steam-venting machine (TR 15, TR 17); telephones carry Mr. C's orders; a radio transmitter carries the Woodsmen's spell (TR 8); a cinema projects the cosmogony (TR 8); televisions play in living rooms and motel rooms; digital cameras monitor a glass box. The revival is an archaeology of media from steam to streaming, and each layer is haunted.

6.4 *The Gnostic Melodrama: Brooks's Moral Occult Literalized*

Peter Brooks's *The Melodramatic Imagination* (1976) argues that melodrama arose in the post-sacred world after the French Revolution to insist on the existence of a "moral occult," a domain of spiritual values hidden beneath the surface of reality. Its rhetoric is excess, polarization, and what Brooks calls the text of muteness: mute characters, gesture, and tableau that signify where words fail.

Twin Peaks began inside melodrama. Its creators acknowledged *Peyton Place* as a model, and the town watches a soap within the show, *Invitation to Love*, whose twin sisters Jade and Emerald, played by one actress, double the series' own doubles. The series then ontologizes Brooks's text of muteness. Dougie is nearly mute; Naido, eyeless, speaks only in sounds; the Log Lady's log must be translated; the Arm speaks obliquely; Hawk's map communicates in symbols.

The **Gnostic melodrama** may now be defined by four features. First, the moral occult is literalized as ontology: the hidden moral forces become lodges with floors and furniture. Second, the virtuous heroine is a divine spark sent into a fallen world, as Laura's orb is sent in TR 8. Third, the villain is an archon who feeds on what he traps. Fourth, and decisively, the viewing apparatus belongs to the archontic system: the glass box, Sarah Palmer's television, and the audience are part of the machinery of entrapment. The category illuminates the series' successors, among them *Lost* (2004–10), *True Detective* (2014), and *The Leftovers* (2014–17), but none of them reaches the fourth feature with the same rigor. *Twin Peaks* is the only Gnostic melodrama that indicts its own screen.

The Lodge's architecture also has literary heirs. Mark Z. Danielewski's *House of Leaves* (2000) builds a house larger inside than out, and Jeff VanderMeer's *Annihilation*

(2014) sends an expedition into a zone where its members meet their doubles and a creature descending a tower writes living words on its walls, a text that feeds. Andrei Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979) had already placed at the center of a forbidden Zone a Room that grants not what one asks for but what one most deeply wants. None of these makes the apparatus of reception into the archon. That remains the singular move of *Twin Peaks*.

CHAPTER SEVEN

VII

Trinity

Part Eight as Gnostic Cosmogony

PART 8 of *The Return* relocates the origin of BOB to the first atomic detonation and answers it with a cosmogony staged in a cinema. It is the corpus's Gnostic Genesis: the point at which Frost's history and Lynch's abstraction fuse, and at which the Lodges finally appear as what Chapter 6 argued they are, media.

The Desert Year 7.1

Part 8 opens its cosmogony with a caption, White Sands, New Mexico, 16 July 1945, 5:29 a.m. Mountain War Time, and a slow advance into the fireball scored to Krzysztof Penderecki's *Threnody to the Victims of Hiroshima* (1960). The test site lay in the Jornada del Muerto, the "journey of the dead man," a name no Lodge cosmologist could improve. Oppenheimer later suggested that the code name Trinity came to him from John Donne's devotional poems, among them the sonnet that asks a three-personed God to batter the speaker's heart. The months and years that followed produced a remarkable cluster of desert revelations, technological, scriptural, and occult, which Frost's SH organizes and Part 8 condenses.



FIG. 7 *The desert year: technological, scriptural, and occult revelations of 1945–1949, which Part 8 of The Return condenses.*

The last row matters most for method. The three theories this dissertation borrows to read *The Return*, Eliade's return, Campbell's monomyth, and Bataille's expenditure, are themselves post-Trinity artifacts. Part 8 shows their occasion. In *Twin Peaks*, modern evil is post-atomic: ancient lore and modern apparatus converge at the moment humanity acquires the power to end the world.

7.2 *The Experiment and the Abortion of Sophia*

In the *Apocryphon of John*, Sophia, the last of the aeons, conceives a thought of her own without her consort and without the consent of the Spirit. It issues as a misshapen being, Yaltabaoth, a lion-faced serpent with eyes like fire. Ashamed, she hides him in a luminous cloud; he steals her power, generates the archons, and boasts that he alone is god. Valentinian systems call such a product an *ektrōma*, a miscarriage.

Inside the fireball of TR 8, a convenience store flickers, Woodsmen move, and the Experiment, gray, eyeless, quasi-female, afloat in the void, disgorges a stream that con-

tains eggs and an orb bearing BOB's face. It is a birth without consort, the abortive emanation of an archon. The credited name carries the argument. Trinity was an experiment, and Sophia's fault was an unauthorized experiment of thought. Kristeva's abject maternal (1980) and Barbara Creed's monstrous-feminine (1993), the archaic mother of horror, describe the figure's affect. But the Gnostic Sophia is not evil; she is erring wisdom, and the Experiment may be less malevolent than blind. The bomb is wisdom's *ektrōma*: knowledge conceiving without the consent of the whole.

The Manichaean cosmogony supplies a second template. The Father of Greatness evokes the Primal Man to battle the invading darkness; the archons devour his five luminous sons; light is mingled with darkness; and the visible cosmos is built as an apparatus to distill it out again. In Mani's myth darkness eats light. *Twin Peaks* inverts the formula with precision: the Lodge eats not light but the suffering wrung from it.

Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) catalogued the Gnostic motifs that organize the rest of the revival: the alien, the stranger thrown into the world, sleep, intoxication, forgetting, and the call from beyond. Jonas's epilogue joined Gnostic thrownness to Heidegger's *Geworfenheit*. Cooper in Las Vegas is the Gnostic stranger in pure form.

Philip K. Dick reached the same cosmology by revelation rather than scholarship. *VALIS* (1981) fictionalizes his visions of 1974, in which a pink beam of information disclosed a Gnostic universe and the formula that the Empire never ended: a single tyrannical time persists beneath the calendar. *Ubik* (1969) had already imagined the dead in "half-life," consulted by the living through electronic apparatus while reality regresses through obsolete forms, coins and appliances reverting to earlier models. The two novels divide *The Return* between them: a timeless Lodge beneath the calendar, and a world of media decaying backward toward steam, in which the dead converse with the living through machines.

The Hymn of the Pearl 7.3

The *Hymn of the Pearl*, preserved in the *Acts of Thomas* (108–113), tells of a prince from the East sent down to Egypt to retrieve a pearl guarded by a serpent. He eats the Egyptians' food, forgets that he is a king's son, and falls into a deep sleep. His parents send a letter that flies to him like an eagle and wakes him. He charms the serpent by naming his father, seizes the pearl, and returns; on the road he meets the radiant robe he left behind, which mirrors him so that he sees himself in it, two and yet one.

The homology with *The Return* is close enough to be startling. Cooper is sent into the world, to Las Vegas, an Egypt of appetite. He eats, coffee and cherry pie, and forgets himself, becoming Dougie. He sleeps through most of the season. A call wakes him: a broadcast pronouncing the name Gordon Cole (TR 15). His task is to retrieve a pearl, Laura, and the corpus has already named the place where her father was first possessed Pearl Lakes. He must meet his double. But where the prince is reunited with his robe,

Cooper consigns his double to destruction (TR 17), and where the prince returns home, Cooper drives into Odessa. *The Return* is the *Hymn of the Pearl* with its ending refused.

The Return is the Hymn of the Pearl with its ending refused.

7.4 *The Fireman's Cinema and the Golden Orb*

The Fireman's palace is an Art Deco interior perched on a rock in a purple sea. In TR 8 he watches the bomb and BOB's orb projected on a screen beside a towering brass apparatus, then rises into the air; a golden effluence streams from his head and gathers into an orb bearing Laura's face. Señorita Dido kisses it and releases it toward Earth through a golden conduit. This is a cosmogony in a movie palace, with the creator as spectator and projector at once.

The theological sources are the metaphysics of light. Plotinus describes the One overflowing like radiance from the sun (*Enneads* V.1.6). Robert Grosseteste's *De luce* (c. 1225) makes light the first corporeal form, which multiplies itself spherically and thereby generates the dimensions of the cosmos. Cinema is the art of projected light, and the White Lodge, at last visible, is a cinema.

It answers the bomb's light with another. The *Bhagavad Gītā* compares the splendor of the universal form to the radiance of a thousand suns bursting at once into the sky (11.12), a verse Oppenheimer associated with Trinity, and at 11.32 Krishna names himself *kāla*, Time grown mighty, the destroyer of worlds; Oppenheimer rendered the word as "Death." The atomic revelation is a revelation of Time as destroyer, and the temporal crisis of *The Return*, its questions whether this is future or past and what year this is, descends from it. Against the theophany of the Whole as annihilation, the White Lodge sends a single face. Margaret Lanterman's telephone message to Hawk in TR 10, that Laura is the one, confirms the election.

Black Fire on White Fire 7.5

Among the symbols on Hawk's map (TR 10–11) is a black fire that Hawk declines to explain, warning that one would not want to know about it. Rabbinic tradition holds that the primordial Torah was written in black fire upon white fire (Jerusalem Talmud, *Sheqalim* 6:1, with midrashic parallels). Gershom Scholem (1965) records Hasidic masters, Levi Isaac of Berditchev among them, who taught that the white fire, the spaces between the letters, is the true Torah, whose letters we cannot yet read.

The image gathers the corpus's other fires. Böhme's dark and light fires (1.1) are its theosophical form; Heraclitus's world-order, an ever-living fire kindled and quenched in measures (DK B30), its cosmological form. Gaston Bachelard's *The Psychoanalysis of Fire* (1938) supplies its psychology: fire is the supremely ambivalent element, and among its complexes are Prometheus's, the will to know as much as the fathers and more (Earle, Cooper), and Empedocles', which unites love and death in the wish to be consumed. "Fire walk with me" is an Empedoclean invocation, a request that one's own consumption keep one company. The Woodsmen's whispered request for a light asks for fire as currency.

The synthesis this dissertation proposes is that the cosmos of *Twin Peaks* is written in black fire on white fire. The Black Lodge is the inscription: the visible letters, the narrative, the legibility of evil. The White Lodge is the luminous ground: the condition of visibility, itself unshown. This is literally the cinematic image, dark figures on projected light, so that the cosmos as scroll is the cosmos as film. The asymmetry of Chapter 1, evil shown and good narrated, turns out to be not a failure of representation but its structure. Good is the light by which evil is shown.

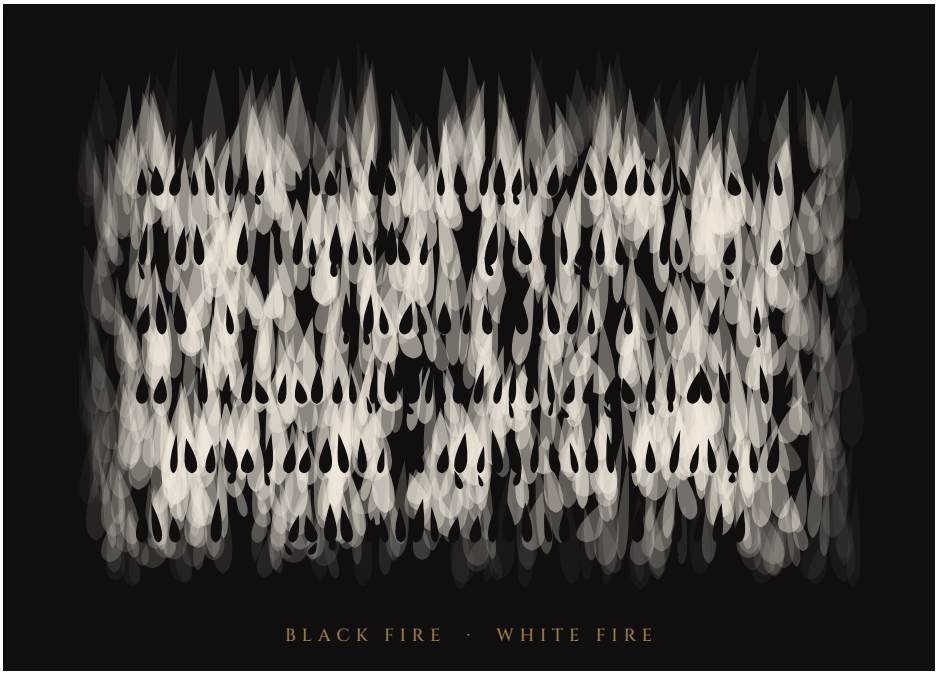


FIG. 8 *Black fire on white fire: the rabbinic image of the primordial Torah as the structure of the cinematic image, dark figures inscribed upon projected light.*

7.6 *The Woodsmen's Broadcast*

In 1956, in the New Mexico desert, an egg hatches a creature part frog and part moth. Woodsmen descend on a small radio station, KPJK, crush the skulls of the receptionist and the disc jockey, and one of them takes the microphone to broadcast, on a loop, an incantation of water, a well, and a horse. Listeners across the region lose consciousness. A girl home from a chaste first kiss, with the Platters' "My Prayer" (1956) earlier on the air, falls asleep, and the frog-moth crawls into her open mouth.

The broadcast is the vector of possession. Marshall McLuhan's *Understanding Media* (1964) called radio a tribal drum, a medium with the power to turn psyche and society into a single echo chamber; Orson Welles's *War of the Worlds* broadcast of 30 October 1938 had demonstrated the power. Adorno's essay on the regression of listening (1938) had diagnosed its effect on the listener. The girl's open mouth is the orifice of the regressed listener, and the Woodsmen, the mindless wooden people of the *Popol Vuh* (5.2), have become broadcasters.

The incantation's horse recurs across the corpus: Sarah's vision of a white horse while Leland kills Maddy (TP 14), the small horse figurine in Carrie Page's house (TR 18), and behind both the pale horse of Revelation (6:8), whose rider is Death and whom

Hades follows. Part 8 locates the origin of modern evil at the junction of the atomic and the electronic. The bomb opens the door; the broadcast carries what comes through into the open mouth of the sleeping listener.

PART FOUR

Ends

VIII · THE GAZE THAT REMAKES
IX · WHAT YEAR IS THIS?
X · THE INEDIBLE

CHAPTER EIGHT

VIII

The Gaze That Remakes

Laura, Judy, and the Necropoetics of the Image

THE extreme negative force that *The Return* names Judy is best understood as the principle of the remade woman: the gaze that compels a living woman to become the image of a dead one. The corpus's names, its cinematic sources, and its final movement converge on this principle, and the revival itself falls under its sign.

Laurel and Pilgrim: An Onomastic Archaeology 8.1

Laura is the laurel. In the first book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, Daphne, fleeing Apollo's sexual pursuit, prays for transformation and becomes a laurel tree, and Apollo adopts the laurel as his emblem. The predator crowns himself with the metamorphosis by which his victim escaped him. Petrarch's Laura, first seen in 1327 and dead of the plague in 1348, is the archetype of the idealized, inaccessible, dead beloved transfigured into literature, and the *Canzoniere* refracts her name into *lauro* (laurel), *l'aura* (the breeze), and *l'oro* (gold). Behind her stands Dante's Beatrice, the dead girl who guides the pilgrim from the *Vita nuova* to the *Paradiso*. A *palmer*, finally, was a medieval pilgrim returned from the Holy Land bearing a palm. Laura Palmer is the laureled pilgrim: the fugitive transformed and the wayfarer bound for a holy land.

The series' other names divide into acknowledged borrowings and homologies. The borrowings are explicit: Maddy Ferguson takes her names from *Vertigo*'s Madeleine and Scottie Ferguson, Waldo the mynah bird from Waldo Lydecker in Preminger's *Laura*,

Gordon Cole from *Sunset Boulevard*. The homologies are offered as such. Sheriff Harry S. Truman shares his name with the president who ordered the atomic bombings, presiding over a town whose cosmic evil TR 8 derives from Trinity. Dale is a valley (2.4). Cooper recalls D. B. Cooper, the hijacker who in November 1971 parachuted into the forests of southwestern Washington and vanished, the Pacific Northwest's archetypal disappearing man. BOB is a palindrome, identical forward and backward, a name native to the Lodge's reversed speech. Carrie Page shares her first name with Carrie White of Stephen King's novel (1974) and Brian De Palma's film (1976), the abused girl crowned in a cruel ritual whose rage destroys the town, and her surname recalls the missing pages of Laura's diary. Alice Tremond is reserved for Chapter 9; Diane and Judy follow here.

8.2 *From Poe's Dictum to Preminger's Portrait*

Poe's "The Philosophy of Composition" (1846) declared the death of a beautiful woman "the most poetical topic in the world." Elisabeth Bronfen's *Over Her Dead Body* (1992) reconstructs the aesthetic that this sentence licensed. Western culture stages femininity and death as mutually constitutive, and the dead woman's body becomes a screen for cultural self-representation within which the violence of representation returns. The pilot's corpse wrapped in plastic fulfills Poe's dictum to the letter; FWWM anatomizes it.

Gaston Bachelard's *Water and Dreams* (1942) names the image the pilot chose. Its "Ophelia complex" describes the reverie in which water becomes the element of a young woman's death, the drowned girl given back by the current as if death were her natural costume. Laura is given back to the shore as Millais's Ophelia (1851–52) floats, pale and composed, except that the flowers have been replaced by plastic sheeting: the shroud has become packaging. Walter Benjamin's "The Storyteller" (1936) supplies the narrative corollary. Death, Benjamin argues, is the sanction of everything the storyteller can tell, and the storyteller borrows his authority from it. A serial in which every episode begins from a dead girl borrows its authority from her death at a usurious rate, and that is algophagy in narrative form.

Preminger's *Laura* (1944) is the series' acknowledged cinematic ancestor. Detective Mark McPherson falls in love with the portrait of Laura Hunt, presumed murdered, while Waldo Lydecker, the possessive mentor who made her, tries to kill her rather than lose her. The faceless corpse belonged to someone else, a model named Diane Redfern, killed in Laura's place. *Twin Peaks* takes the portrait, which becomes the homecoming photograph; the detective's devotion to a dead girl's image; and Waldo, now a mynah bird whose mimicry of Laura's last words Cooper captures on a voice-activated recorder, the bird become a recording medium. The Diane of *Laura* is a substitute victim. *The Return*'s Diane, raped by Mr. C (she discloses it in TR 16), replicated as a tul-

pa, and in TR 18 the woman who covers Cooper's face, is the series' substitute victim too.

Vertigo *and the Name of Judy* 8.3

In Hitchcock's *Vertigo* (1958), Scottie Ferguson becomes obsessed with "Madeleine," a role played by Judy Barton in a scheme staged by Gavin Elster. After Madeleine's staged death, Scottie meets Judy and remakes her, hair, clothes, and bearing, into the dead woman, then takes her back to the mission tower where the original death was staged. A dark figure, a nun, emerges from the shadows; Judy, startled, falls to her death. Laura Mulvey (1975) used *Vertigo* to anatomize voyeuristic and fetishistic scopophilia. Tania Modleski's *The Women Who Knew Too Much* (1988) recovered the film's identification with feminine suffering and placed Judy's perspective at its center.

Twin Peaks reenacts *Vertigo* twice. Late in the first season, Donna and James dress Maddy in a blonde wig to impersonate Laura, and in TP 14 Leland murders her: the remade double is killed, as Judy was. Then the name arrives. In FWWM, Phillip Jeffries insists that no one will talk about Judy. In TR 17, Gordon Cole explains an extreme negative force called Jowday, shortened to Judy. In TR 18, Cooper, now calling himself Richard, finds Carrie Page by way of Judy's Coffee Shop in Odessa, Texas, and drives her through the night to the Palmer house. A stranger, Alice Tremond, owns it. A mother's voice calls "Laura" from within, and Carrie screams. The terminal movement of *Vertigo* is restaged almost beat for beat: the remade woman, the return to the site of the death, the voice from the dark, the scream.

The proposal of this chapter follows. **Judy names the force of remaking**, the gaze that compels a living woman to become the image of a dead one. Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) defines melancholia as the refusal to relinquish a lost object, which the ego instead incorporates, and Karl Abraham (1924) characterized melancholic incorporation as oral and cannibalistic: the melancholic devours the dead. Cooper's refusal to let Laura be dead, his attempt to undo her death, is melancholic incorporation. It is algophagy in its most refined form, wearing the mask of rescue, and it ends in a world whose coffee shop bears Judy's name.

The revival falls under the same sign. *The Return* is itself the remaking of a dead series, a *Vertigo*-structure on the scale of the medium: an audience asked its creators to bring back the dead girl and the old Cooper. Lynch and Frost refused both nostalgias, withholding Cooper for most of the season and giving the audience a Laura who screams. Goethe's Faust stakes his soul on the moment he will beg to stay because it is so beautiful, and he is saved at the end by the Eternal Feminine that draws us upward (1808; 1832). *The Return* refuses the Goethean apotheosis. Its eternal feminine does not draw the hero upward. She screams.

Its eternal feminine does not draw the hero upward. She screams.

Fredric Jameson's *Postmodernism* (1991), which counted *Blue Velvet* among its exhibits, diagnosed the "nostalgia mode" as the cultural logic of a society that can represent its past only as period style. *The Return* refuses that logic. Its 1956 is a scene of possession, not a look, and its 1989 is a crime scene that the hero cannot reenter without making things worse.

8.4 *Aura and* l'aura*: The Reproduced Girl*

Walter Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technological reproducibility (1935–36) defines aura as the unique appearance of a distance, however near it may be, and argues that reproduction liquidates aura by substituting a plurality of copies for a unique existence. Petrarch's pun on *l'aura* here meets Benjamin's concept. Laura Palmer is the aura in the age of its televisual reproduction: the homecoming photograph multiplied in a trophy case, in newspapers, on millions of screens, and through decades of fan culture. *The Return* subjects the photograph first to Sarah's assault with a broken bottle and then to the erasure of its subject after Cooper's intervention. The algophagic broadcast liquidates Laura's aura into reproducible spectacle. The scream, singular, unseen in its object, unrepeatable as event, returns aura as a here-and-now that cannot be reproduced.

The Blue Rose completes the pattern. In Tennessee Williams's *The Glass Menagerie* (1944), a fragile girl named Laura is nicknamed "Blue Roses" by the boy who misheard her illness, pleurosis. Novalis's blue flower in *Heinrich von Ofterdingen* (1802) is Romanticism's emblem of infinite longing. The FBI's Blue Rose is the emblem of artificial doubles. The impossible flower and the name Laura meet in two American texts, and the homology is exact: the blue rose names the girl who cannot exist in the world as she is desired.

CHAPTER NINE

IX

What Year Is This?

The Failure of Return

The Return tests every major model of return available to Western and Indian thought and lets each one fail. Only one return succeeds, the return of the repressed, and it arrives as a scream.

Four Returns 9.1

Mircea Eliade's *The Myth of the Eternal Return* (1949) argues that archaic humanity abolished profane time by ritually repeating the cosmogony and returning to *illud tempus*, the time of origins. Its chapter on the "terror of history" diagnoses modern historical man, who must suffer history as meaningless. Cooper's journey in TR 17 is the archaic return in its purest form. He travels to the town's *illud tempus*, the night of 23 February 1989, the founding murder, to abolish history's terror by abolishing its origin. The body vanishes from the riverbank, and Pete Martell goes fishing and finds nothing. But the night does not let Laura go.

Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843) distinguishes recollection, which repeats backward, from repetition, which recollects forward. Its pseudonymous author, Constantin Constantius, returns to Berlin to repeat a happy visit, the same lodgings and the same farce at the Königstädter Theater, and the repetition fails; only the religious achieves true repetition, as Job receives everything double. Cooper mistakes recollection for repetition. He tries to recover a lost past rather than to receive a renewed future.

Nietzsche's *The Gay Science* (§341, 1882) imagines a demon who announces, in one's loneliest loneliness, that every pain and every joy will return innumerable times; the test of *amor fati* is to bless the announcement. The corpus sets Nietzsche against Ivan Karamazov (10.3). To affirm Laura's death eternally would be the supreme algophagy, the digestion of all suffering into necessity. Cooper rightly refuses *amor fati*, but refusal does not undo.

Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) describes the compulsion to repeat, the traumatic dream, the child's game of *fort/da*, and the death drive. It describes, too, the return of the repressed, and this is the only return that succeeds in TR 18. In Odessa, a woman who does not know she is Laura is brought to the house where the repressed lives, and it returns as a scream. Deleuze's *Difference and Repetition* (1968) supplies the formula for Carrie Page: repetition produces difference, and Carrie is a repetition of Laura irreducible to identity.

Augustine's analysis of time in the eleventh book of the *Confessions* underlies all four. There is a present of things past, which is memory; a present of things present, which is attention; and a present of things future, which is expectation; and time itself is a distention of the soul (*distentio animi*). MIKE's incantation speaks of a darkness of future past, and in TR 2 he asks Cooper whether it is future or past. The question is Augustinian. Time in *Twin Peaks* is not a line but the distention of a soul, and the soul it distends is wounded.

Three further models complete the census. Plato's Myth of Er (*Republic* X, 614b–621d) sends the dead to choose their next lives and then to drink from the River of Unheeding, so that they enter the new life forgetting the old. Carrie Page is such a soul, living in Odessa a life chosen after forgetting, and her scream at the Palmer house is anamnesis in the Platonic sense: a recollection that returns all at once and cannot be borne. Joseph Campbell's monomyth (1949) closes with the hero's crossing of the return threshold and his emergence as master of the two worlds, bearing a boon to his community. Cooper crosses a threshold at mile 430 and becomes master of nothing, bringing no boon to anyone, which writes the monomyth's refusal into its final stage. Henri Bergson's *Matter and Memory* (1896) and Deleuze's *Cinema 2* (1985) supply the image of time that MIKE's question presupposes: at every instant the present splits into a present that passes and a past that is preserved, and the time-image makes that split visible as a crystal. The Red Room is such a crystal, a room in which past and present are visible at once and indiscernible, and the question whether it is future or past is the crystal's own.



FIG. 9 *Eight models of return and their fates in The Return. Only the return of the repressed succeeds, and it arrives as a scream.*

Orpheus, Parzival, and the Wrong Question 9.2

The Orphic topology of TR 17 is unmistakable (Virgil, *Georgics* IV; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* X): a descent into the night of a death, a leading-out by the hand through dark woods, and a disappearance accompanied by a cry. Cooper takes Laura's hand and leads her toward safety; she vanishes, and a scream fills the forest.

The Grail romance supplies the deeper template. In Wolfram von Eschenbach's *Parzival* (c. 1200–1210), the young knight arrives at the Grail castle but, constrained by his tutor Gurnemanz's counsel not to ask many questions, fails to ask the wounded king Anfortas what ails him. The land remains waste until, years later, he returns and asks. Chrétien's *Perceval* (c. 1180s) had posed the questions as whom the Grail serves and why the lance bleeds. Wagner's *Parsifal* (1882) crystallized the hero as the pure fool made wise through compassion, *durch Mitleid wissend, der reine Tor*. Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance* (1920) and Eliot's *The Waste Land* (1922) made the Fisher King and his blighted land the master myth of modern devastation, and Glastonbury Grove sets Arthurian Avalon at the Lodge's very door.

Dougie Jones is the pure fool. His simple goodness heals the Mitchum brothers, Janey-E, Sonny Jim, and Bushnell Mullins. When Cooper wakes and announces that he is the FBI (TR 16), he loses the fool's compassion and becomes the knight of the quest. In TR 18 he asks the wrong question. "What year is this?" is chronological and forensic, whereas the Grail requires a question that is compassionate and present-tense: what ails you? Cooper asks the detective's question in the place where the knight's was required, and the waste land remains.

He asks the detective's question in the place where the knight's was required.

9.3 *The Angel of History in Odessa*

Benjamin's ninth thesis "On the Concept of History" (1940) reads Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus* as the angel of history. His face is turned toward the past; where we perceive a chain of events, he sees one single catastrophe that keeps piling wreckage upon wreckage. He would like to stay, awaken the dead, and make whole what has been smashed, but a storm blowing from Paradise, the storm we call progress, drives him irresistibly into the future. Cooper is this angel. He wants to awaken the dead and make whole what has been smashed, and time's storm blows him into Odessa.

Benjamin's second thesis holds that the past carries a secret index by which it is referred to redemption, and a late fragment adds that every second was, for the Jewish tradition, the strait gate through which the Messiah might enter. "What year is this?" is the question of one who seeks the messianic now within homogeneous, empty time and finds only a date. The corpus has two angels: FWWM's, which descends to the victim, and Benjamin's, which cannot reach her.

Kafka's parable "Before the Law" (1915) is the inverse image of Cooper's quarter-century. A man from the country waits his whole life before a door that, the doorkeeper tells him at the end, was meant only for him. Cooper spends twenty-five years on the other side of such a door, inside the Waiting Room, and the revival's first Parts record a waiting that has become a place.

Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Lathe of Heaven* (1971), set in Portland, gives the Pacific Northwest its own fable of retroactive repair. George Orr's dreams change reality, and the psychiatrist William Haber exploits them to improve the world, with catastrophic results; the novel's Taoist ethic of *wu wei* counsels against the will to fix reality through the dream, and its title derives from an English rendering of the *Zhuangzi*. Cooper in TR 17–18 is Haber: the will to repair the past through the dream produces a worse

world. Bradbury's carousel in *Something Wicked This Way Comes*, which runs backward to make its riders young again, is the carnival's cruelest lure for the same reason. Temporal reversal is a temptation, not a rescue.

The Red King's Dream and Our Town 9.4

In the fourth chapter of *Through the Looking-Glass* (1871), Tweedledee tells Alice that she is only a sort of thing in the Red King's dream, and Tweedledum adds that if the King were to wake, she would go out, bang, just like a candle. In TR 18 the Palmer house belongs to a woman named Alice Tremond, played by the house's actual owner, who says she bought it from a Mrs. Chalfont. The Red Room has been the corpus's dream-space since TP 2. A scream sounds, and the lights of the house go out, bang, like a candle. Of all the homologies this dissertation proposes, it is the most exact.

Jorge Luis Borges's "The Circular Ruins" (1940) supplies the formula of the dreamed. A magician dreams a son into being and sends him into the world; the son alone is unharmed by fire, which marks him as a phantom. At the end, fire engulfs the magician's own ruins and does not burn him, and he understands, with relief, with humiliation, with terror, that he too is an appearance dreamed by another. MIKE's incantation names a magician who longs to see and a voice that chants between two worlds, and it closes with the words *fire walk with me*. Borges's magician walks unburned through fire and learns that he is dreamed. "Fire walk with me" is the dreamed one's formula, and Gordon Cole's question in TR 14, who is the dreamer, receives its Borgesian answer: there is no last dreamer, only the regress. The *Zhuangzi* (ch. 2) had stated the regress two millennia earlier, when Zhuang Zhou dreamed he was a butterfly and woke unable to tell whether he was a man who had dreamed of being a butterfly or a butterfly dreaming of being a man.

Thornton Wilder's *Our Town* (1938) supplies the scene. In its third act Emily Webb, dead in childbirth, chooses against the counsel of the dead to relive her twelfth birthday. She finds the ordinary day unbearable because the living never truly look at one another, and she asks the Stage Manager whether anyone ever realizes life while living it. No, he answers; the saints and poets, perhaps, some. In TR 18 Carrie Page is brought back to the Palmer house, an ordinary porch on an ordinary night, and hears her mother's voice call her name, and she screams. Emily's return is aborted by unbearable seeing, Laura's by unbearable hearing. Wilder's Stage Manager, who knows the dead and arranges their visits, finds his avatars in Gordon Cole, played by the author, and in the Fireman. And *The Wizard of Oz* (1939), a touchstone Lynch invoked throughout his career, completes the comparison by contrast. Dorothy wakes and there is no place like home. Carrie wakes, and there is no home.

CHAPTER TEN

X

The Inedible

Whisper, Ring, Scream

AGAINST algophagy the corpus produces three forms of suffering that resist consumption: the whisper (1990), the ring (1992), and the scream (2017). They escalate from speech to act to event. Together they constitute the work's ethical content and yield its final position, an anti-theodical cosmology joined to a pedagogy of attention.

The Whisper: Repression and the White Fire 10.1

In the Red Room dream of TP 2, Laura leans to Cooper and whispers the killer's identity. He wakes and forgets. Only in TP 16 does he recover it: her father killed her. Freud's *Interpretation of Dreams* (1900, ch. VII.A) attributes the forgetting of dreams to resistance. The detective's amnesia is the culture's repression of paternal violence, and BOB is the dream-work's displacement of the father. The series spends a season inside the forgetting.

In TR 2, and again beneath the closing credits of TR 18, Laura whispers to Cooper once more, and this time we hear nothing. The whisper has evolved from repressed knowledge into absolute secret. Derrida's *The Gift of Death* (1992) and *Passions* (1993) theorize a secret that remains secret even when shared, a secret with no content awaiting revelation. The Kabbalistic white fire of 7.5, letters not yet legible, is its theological form. The whisper is addressed to one and withheld from the many; it is the anti-broadcast. What cannot be transmitted cannot be consumed.

What cannot be transmitted cannot be consumed.

10.2 *The Ring: Gyges Inverted*

In the second book of the *Republic* (359d–360d), Glaucon tells of Gyges's ring, which grants invisibility and therefore impunity, to test whether anyone would choose justice for its own sake. Tolkien's Ring (1954–55) adds corruption and the wraith-world. The Owl Cave ring of *Twin Peaks* reverses Gyges. It grants not impunity but exposure, marking its wearers for the Lodge: Teresa Banks, whom Leland murdered a year before Laura; Laura herself; and Dougie.

In the train car of FWWM, where the possessed Leland has bound Laura and Ronette Pulaski, and as BOB prepares to make Laura his next host, MIKE throws the ring into the car. Laura, warned in a dream not to take it, puts it on, and her father murders her. Ronette, whom he has also assaulted, survives; she is the girl who walks across the railroad bridge in the pilot. Laura chooses to die rather than to become BOB's vessel and the instrument of further suffering, as her father had become. Socrates in the *Gorgias* (469b–c) holds that doing injustice is the greatest of evils and that he would rather suffer it than do it. Laura's choice is the Socratic choice and the anti-Gyges choice. It is also the only act in the corpus that removes a host from algophagic circulation: it denies BOB his supply. Lacan's seventh seminar (1959–60) reads Antigone's choice of death as a refusal to give ground on her desire, and Weil's *Gravity and Grace* (1947) describes decreation, the self's consent to its own undoing so that grace may enter. In FWWM, grace does enter: the angel arrives.

The Return revises that consolation. In TR 2 Laura is torn screaming from the Red Room; she is not at rest. Her act was free and yet did not close the circuit, because the circuit includes the audience's desire to see her again. Leland's karmic mercy in TP 16 and Laura's angel in FWWM are both withdrawn. *The Return* retracts its own theodicy.

10.3 *The Scream: Useless Suffering and the Short Circuit*

Francis Bacon told David Sylvester that he had wanted to paint the scream more than the horror. Edvard Munch recorded sensing an infinite scream passing through nature before he painted *The Scream* (1893). Laura's scream in TR 18 is a scream without the horror: we do not see what she sees, the horror is withheld, and the scream is pure.

Emmanuel Levinas's "Useless Suffering" (1982) argues that suffering is in itself for nothing, that the justification of the neighbor's pain is the source of all immorality, and

that the century of Auschwitz ended theodicy. In "Rebellion," the great chapter of *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880), Ivan respectfully returns his ticket to any harmony purchased with the tears of a tortured child. Hegel's *Lectures on the Philosophy of History* call history the slaughter-bench on which the happiness of peoples has been sacrificed, and ask at once to what final purpose. Theodicy is the philosophical form of algophagy, the digestion of suffering into meaning. Adorno's *Negative Dialectics* (1966) states the counter-principle: the need to let suffering speak is the condition of all truth. Laura's scream is the inedible in its purest form, suffering that speaks without being converted into meaning, narrative, or spectacle.

Louis Althusser (1970) described ideology as a hailing: a voice calls "Hey, you there!" and the individual turns, becoming a subject. Sarah's voice calls "Laura," and the woman hailed does not turn into the role. She screams. The final scream is a counter-interpellation.

The corpus is bracketed by screams. In the pilot Sarah Palmer screams into the telephone when she understands that her daughter is gone; in TR 18 the daughter screams when her mother's voice calls her name. The mother's scream of grief was consumable, the signature sound of melodrama. The daughter's is not. Between them, near the close of TR 15, an anonymous young woman displaced from her booth at the Roadhouse crawls across the floor and screams, a scream the narrative neither explains nor uses.

The formal effect of the final scream is electrical: the lights of the Palmer house go out. A short circuit is an abnormal path of negligible resistance, through which current surges until the protection trips. The algophagic circuit, confronted with a pain it cannot route as nourishment, overloads and interrupts itself. Carrie White's rage turned her town's electricity against it; Carrie Page's scream turns the house dark. That darkness is also the Fourth state of the *Māṇḍūkya* (2.2), the silence after the syllable. The end of the broadcast and the awakening of the dreamer are one event.

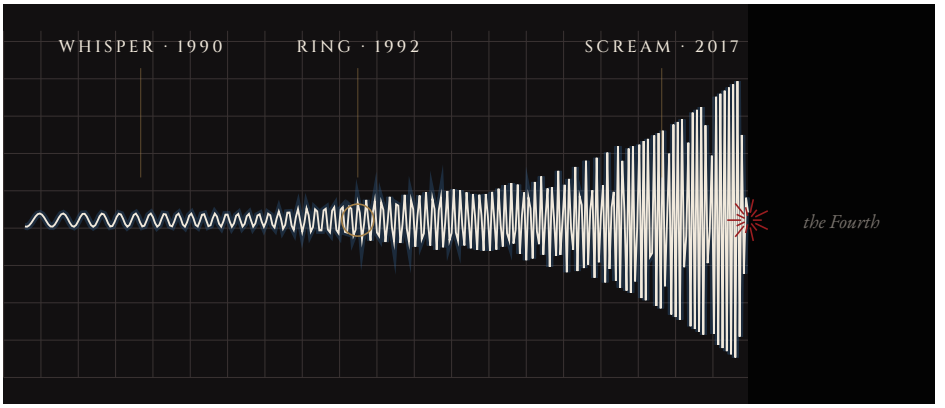


FIG. 10 *Whisper, ring, scream: the escalation from speech to act to event, ending in a short circuit and the soundless Fourth.*

10.4 *Two Spectatorships*

The corpus dramatizes two ways of watching. The Fireman listens to a gramophone (TR 1), watches the bomb on a screen (TR 8), and answers what he sees with a gift. The Lodge watches in order to consume: BOB's grin; the glass box and its doomed watchers (TR 1); Sarah Palmer before a television that plays predators devouring prey and a boxing bout whose seconds loop and stutter. Simone Weil wrote to Joë Bousquet in 1942 that attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity, and *Gravity and Grace* calls absolutely unmixed attention prayer. Consumption and attention are the two modes of spectatorship, and Lynch's meditative practice is a discipline of the second: transcending as attention without appetite.

The Return's formal strategies are a pedagogy of attention.

1. **Duration.** A man sweeps the Roadhouse floor in a single long take (TR 7).
2. **Frustration.** Dougie occupies most of the season, withholding the Cooper the audience craved.
3. **Refusal of nostalgia.** The old cast appear aged and diminished, the old music returns sparingly.
4. **Liturgy.** Nearly every Part closes with a performance at the Roadhouse, a recessional that returns the viewer to communal listening.
5. **Abstraction.** Part 8 suspends narrative almost entirely.

These devices deny the viewer garmonbozia, the quick gratification and the spectacle of Laura's suffering, and retrain appetite into attention. Kafka's "A Hunger Artist" (1922) staged fasting as spectacle and ended with a panther devouring its meat with joy. *The Return* makes its audience fast, so that attention might replace hunger.

Mortality enters the fiction without being consumed by it. Catherine Coulson filmed the Log Lady's final scenes while dying and died in 2015, and her farewell call to Hawk in TR 15 is at once fiction and leave-taking. Miguel Ferrer and Warren Frost died before broadcast; Don S. Davis appears only as an archival image. *The Return* is a work of mourning rather than of melancholic consumption: it lets its dead be dead. Lynch's own death in January 2025 sealed the corpus and turned Gordon Cole's last scenes, retroactively, into an author's farewell. The posthumous corpus is now the scene in which every viewer chooses between consuming Lynch's image as nostalgia and attending to the work.

CONCLUSION

Toward a Post-Algophagic Spectatorship

Twin Peaks is a twenty-seven-year inquiry into who eats Laura Palmer, and its answer, delivered in the dark of the Palmer house, implicates everyone who watched. This dissertation has made five contributions.

1. **Algophagy** as an analytic category: the extraction, transmission, and consumption of suffering, traced across five registers, the occult, the social, the familial, the epistemic, and the technological, whose isomorphism the corpus's syncretism names in mutually incompatible vocabularies (Chapter 5).
2. **The Gnostic melodrama** as a genre: melodrama whose moral occult is literalized as Gnostic ontology and whose viewing apparatus belongs to the archontic system (Chapter 6).
3. **The Lodge as relay**: a media-theological reading in which the Red Room is analog television seen from inside, the White Lodge is cinema, and the cosmos is written in black fire on white fire (Chapters 6–7).
4. **The poetics of the inedible**: whisper, ring, and scream as an escalation from speech to act to event, each resisting conversion into narrative, spectacle, or theodicy (Chapter 10).
5. **A set of comparative nodes** not previously assembled: the *Hymn of the Pearl* and Pearl Lakes; the wooden and maize people of the *Popol Vuh*; Borges's magician who

walks unburned through fire; Carroll's Red King and Alice Tremond; the rabbinic black fire; *Vertigo*'s Judy; and Wilder's Emily Webb.

The implications extend beyond the corpus. For television studies, the serial form appears as a ritual technology for the circulation of a victim's image, and the age of revivals and legacy sequels operates under the sign of Judy, the compulsion to remake dead works in the image of their former selves. *The Return* is the one revival that indicts its own desire. For the philosophy of religion, *Twin Peaks* belongs beside Levinas and Ivan Karamazov as an anti-theodical cosmology: the good does not justify suffering but sends light into it, and the White Lodge's gift is not an explanation but a presence, an angel at the end of a film, an orb with a face. For the ethics of spectatorship, the decisive line runs not between depicting and refusing to depict suffering but between consuming and attending, and Lynch's meditative aesthetics proposes attention without appetite as the post-algophagic stance.

The limits of the argument are equally clear. Authorial intention cannot be proven, and many correspondences proposed here are homologies. The danger of over-reading is real, above all for a work that trains its interpreters in paranoia. The vast online exegesis that greeted *The Return*, its frame-by-frame decodings and reconstructed timelines, reproduces the Lodge's appetite in hermeneutic form: every clue extracted from Laura's suffering is another spoonful of creamed corn. Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's "Paranoid Reading and Reparative Reading" (2003) names the alternative. Paranoid reading anticipates, exposes, and trusts in the efficacy of knowledge; reparative reading assembles and sustains, conferring plenitude on an object that will then nourish rather than be consumed. A post-algophagic criticism of *Twin Peaks* would be reparative. It would attend to the work without demanding that its wounds yield secrets.

This dissertation must therefore end by declining to decode the scream. It has named the scream's conditions, what it refuses, what it shorts, what it ends, but not its content, which the work withholds and which no reading should extract. The whisper belongs to Cooper. The scream belongs to Laura.

"Who killed Laura Palmer?" was answered in 1990. "Who eats her?" was answered in 2017, and the answer is the apparatus that includes us. What remains is the question the Grail knight should have asked and the detective did not: not what year it is, but what ails her. No clue can answer that question. The scream is not a clue. It is the end of clues.

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◆

KEYWORDS

Twin Peaks · David Lynch · Mark Frost · algophagy · garmonbozia · Gnostic melodrama · moral occult · sacrificial broadcast · the inedible · Black Lodge · White Lodge · Theosophy · Dweller on the Threshold · doppelgänger · tulpa · Transcendental Meditation · Advaita Vedānta · *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad* · Gnosticism · *Hymn of the Pearl* · Lurianic Kabbalah · black fire on white fire · *Popol Vuh* · René Girard · scapegoat mechanism · pharmakon · Georges Bataille · accursed share · Simone Weil · affliction · attention · Emmanuel Levinas · useless suffering · anti-theodicy · haunted media · media archaeology · hauntology · electricity · serial television · Trinity test · *Fire Walk With Me* · *The Return* · Laura Palmer · *Vertigo* · necropoetics · aura · eternal return · repetition · Grail question · folk horror · faciality · spectatorship